

WHEN IS EVERY RATIONAL HODGE CLASS ALGEBRAIC?

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ABSTRACT. We determine which combinations of the standard statements around the rational Hodge conjecture imply it. Every such combination contains the conjecture modulo abelian varieties, unless it contains both the Lefschetz standard conjecture and André’s conjecture that every Hodge class is motivated, a pair equivalent to the Hodge conjecture itself. Granting the recently claimed Hodge conjecture for CM abelian varieties, we prove it for every Fermat variety and reduce the abelian case to propagation from CM points. For Weil classes we prove a criterion by bounded degree at CM points, and we extract from Schoen’s cycles one subvariety whose semiregularity would settle the split Weil families over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ in every dimension. The Hodge conjecture itself is not proved.

1. INTRODUCTION

Let X be a smooth complex projective variety. A class in $H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$ is a *Hodge class* if its image in $H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{C})$ lies in $H^{p,p}(X)$, and it is *algebraic* if it is a rational linear combination of the classes of subvarieties of codimension p . Algebraic classes are Hodge classes. Hodge asked for the converse [Hod52].

Conjecture 1.1 (Hodge). *For every smooth complex projective variety X and every $p \geq 0$, every Hodge class in $H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$ is algebraic.*

We write (HC) for this statement. It holds for $p \leq 1$ and $p \geq \dim X - 1$, so for every variety of dimension at most three, and it is open in general. The question in the title has a precise form: *from which of the statements that the literature has isolated does (HC) follow?* This paper answers that question, proves the conditional theorems that the answer allows, and stops at the first statement on each route that we cannot prove. We do not prove the Hodge conjecture, and no statement below should be read as a claim that it holds.¹

The statements. The following statements are made precise in Definition 2.7.

- (F2) The Hodge conjecture for abelian varieties.
- (F3') The Hodge conjecture modulo abelian varieties: every Hodge class on every X is a sum of classes $\Gamma_*\gamma$, where γ is a Hodge class on an abelian variety B and Γ is an algebraic cycle on $B \times X$.
- (L) The Lefschetz standard conjecture $B(X)$ of Grothendieck [Gro69], for every X .
- (M) Every Hodge class is motivated in the sense of André [And96].

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Source, figures and verification code: <https://github.com/creelie/e84hc>, archived on Zenodo as doi:10.5281/zenodo.23234362.

¹Here and below a statement is called *proved* when it is proved in this paper or in refereed work. Results that are available only as preprints are marked as such where they are used. The one preprint on which a theorem of this paper depends, [Ope26b], enters only as an explicit hypothesis.

- (V) The variational Hodge conjecture: in a smooth projective family over a smooth connected base, a flat family of rational classes that is algebraic on one fibre is algebraic on every fibre.
- (CM) The Hodge conjecture for abelian varieties of CM type.
- (IP) Propagation from CM points: (V) for polarized abelian schemes and classes that are algebraic on a fibre of CM type.

The statement (CM) is the main theorem claimed in the preprint [Ope26b], which has not been refereed. We have not verified its proof, and Section 4.1 says which parts of it we have checked.

Theorem A. *The following are equivalent:*

- (i) (HC);
- (ii) (F2) and (F3');
- (iii) (L) and (F3');
- (iv) (V) and (F3');
- (v) (CM), (IP) and (F3');
- (vi) (L) and (M).

The implications from (ii)–(vi) to (i) combine known theorems of André, Deligne, Abdulali and Milne with two observations of this paper: (F3') implies (M) (Proposition 2.9), and (CM) together with (IP) implies (F2) (Proposition 4.4). The theorem is proved in Section 4.3. The next theorem says that these are all the ways in which the conjecture follows from the statements above, together with the other statements the paper meets: the semiregularity of Schoen's subvariety (Question 5.14), and the Hodge conjecture for Fermat varieties and for the Weil classes of the split Weil families over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$.

Theorem B (The routes). *Let S be a set of the statements of Table 1 that does not contain (HC), and suppose that (HC) follows from S by the implications of Table 1. Then*

- (a) *either S contains (F3') together with one of (F2), (L), (V), or both of (CM) and (IP);*
- (b) *or S contains both (L) and (M).*

Each of the five minimal sets so described implies (HC), and each implies every statement of Table 1 except the semiregularity of Schoen's subvariety.

So there are two ways in. One passes through abelian varieties and needs (F3') together with a statement that implies (F2); the other avoids abelian varieties and assumes (L) and (M), which by Theorem A is the Hodge conjecture in another form. In particular (F2) and (F3') can be avoided as hypotheses, but never as consequences, and Schoen's subvariety lies on no route at all (Corollary 6.2). The routes are drawn in Figure 1.

The remaining results are conditional on one statement, or prove one case. Let $X_m^n \subseteq \mathbb{P}^{n+1}$ be the Fermat variety $x_0^n + \cdots + x_{n+1}^n = 0$.

Theorem C. *Assume (CM). Then the Hodge conjecture holds for every Fermat variety X_m^n , for every product of Fermat varieties of any degrees and dimensions, and for every smooth projective variety onto which such a product maps surjectively. Without any hypothesis, (F3') holds for all of these varieties.*

Fermat varieties are the first varieties on which the conjecture was studied in every dimension [Ran80, Shi79], and unconditional proofs are known only for special degrees (Remark 3.7). The proof of Theorem C uses the inductive structure of Shioda and Katsura [SK79] to dominate every Fermat variety by a product of Fermat curves, blown up along smooth centres, and the fact that Fermat curves have Jacobians of CM type.

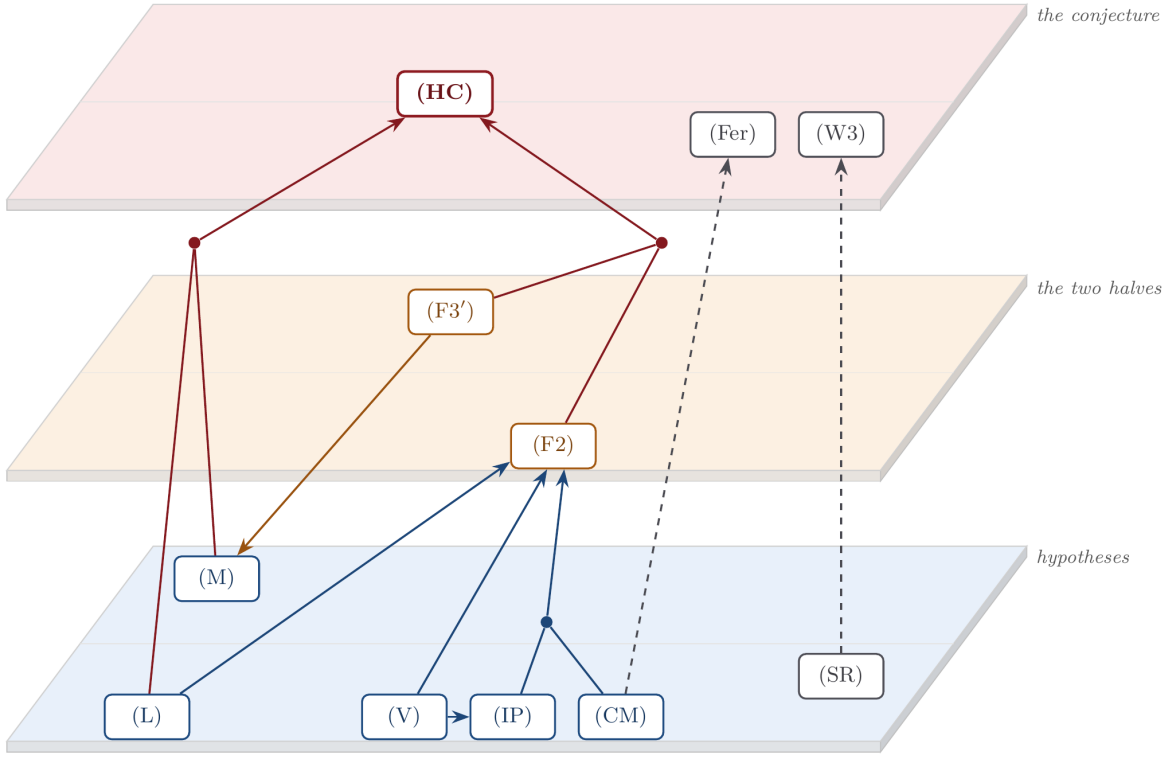


FIGURE 1. The routes of Theorem B. Hypotheses lie on the bottom layer, the two halves (F2) and (F3') in the middle, and (HC) on top. Arrows are implications of Table 1. At each dot two lines combine into a conjunction: $(CM) \wedge (IP) \Rightarrow (F2)$, $(L) \wedge (M) \Rightarrow (HC)$ and $(F2) \wedge (F3') \Rightarrow (HC)$. The arrows from (HC) and (F2) to the statements they contain are not drawn. The dashed arrows on the right lead to the special cases (Fer) and (W3) of Section 6, and not to (HC).

Abelian varieties of Weil type are where (F2) is hardest. On the split Weil family of an imaginary quadratic field over its Shimura variety S (Section 4.4), write $\Sigma \subseteq S$ for the set of members on which the Weil classes are algebraic, and $\Sigma_d \subseteq \Sigma$ for the set where they have algebraic representatives of degree at most d (Definition 4.5).

Theorem D. *Each Σ_d is Zariski closed in S , and $\Sigma = \bigcup_d \Sigma_d$. The following are equivalent:*

- (i) $\Sigma = S$;
- (ii) $\Sigma_d = S$ for some d ;
- (iii) for some d , the CM points in Σ_d are not contained in any finite union of proper special subvarieties of S .

Under (CM) every CM point of S lies in Σ .

So under (CM) the Weil classes are algebraic on the whole family exactly when, at the CM points, they have algebraic representatives of uniformly bounded degree on a set that is not trapped in finitely many proper Shimura subvarieties. The equivalence of (ii) and (iii) is where the André–Oort conjecture, proved by Pila, Shankar and Tsimerman [PST21], enters.

The last result concerns the only cycles known to represent Weil classes at members with maximal Hodge group in every dimension, those constructed by Schoen [Sch88]. Let X be a

curve of genus $n + 1 \geq 3$, let $C \rightarrow X$ be the étale cyclic triple cover given by a line bundle of order three, and let B be its Prym variety, an abelian variety of dimension $2n$ of Weil type for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ with polarization class η .

Theorem E. *There is an irreducible subvariety $Y \subseteq B$ of dimension n , built from one of the three components into which Schoen's cover splits over the canonical system of X , whose class pairs nontrivially with the Weil classes of B . If the Hodge group of B is maximal, which holds for very general (X, C) , then*

$$\mathrm{cl}(Y) = c\eta^n + w, \quad c \in \mathbb{Q}_{>0}, \quad 0 \neq w \text{ a Weil class.}$$

If Y is semiregular for one such B , the Weil classes are algebraic on every member of the split Weil family of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ in dimension $2n$.

For $n \leq 3$ this family is already covered by Schoen's work [Sch88, Sch98]. For $n \geq 4$ it is not: the Prym locus has dimension $3n$ and the family has dimension n^2 , so Y would have to deform in $n^2 - 3n$ further directions. The proof of the pairing in Theorem E is a short computation with twisted coefficients on the symmetric product of X , and it also gives a proof of Schoen's theorem that B carries algebraic Weil classes (Corollary 5.7). We give the evidence on both sides of Question 5.14 in Section 5.6, including a precise analogy with the Abel–Jacobi curve, which is not semiregular, and with a question of Markman about a weak form of the semiregularity theorem.

What is not proved. None of the statements (F2), (F3'), (L), (M), (V), (IP) is proved here, and (CM) is used only as a hypothesis. The Hodge conjecture is open, and by Corollary 6.2 every set of these statements from which it follows also implies (F2) and (F3'). Section 7 lists what is proved and what is not, and names the first open cases: for (F2), the Weil classes of nonsplit abelian sixfolds and of abelian eightfolds, and the exceptional classes on the square of a Mumford fourfold; for (F3'), the square of a K3 surface with real multiplication.

Organization. Section 2 proves the reductions that hold for every variety and defines the statements. Section 3 proves Theorem C. Section 4 treats (CM) and (IP), proves Theorem A, and proves Theorem D. Section 5 proves Theorem E and the transfer theorem for Weil classes. Section 6 proves Theorem B. Section 7 collects what is proved and what is not, and Appendix A describes the machine checks of the finite steps. No proof in this paper depends on a computer.

Conventions. Varieties are complex, smooth, projective and, unless said otherwise, connected. Cohomology is singular cohomology with rational coefficients. For a variety X we write $\mathrm{Hdg}^p(X) \subseteq H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$ for the Hodge classes and $\mathrm{Alg}^p(X) \subseteq \mathrm{Hdg}^p(X)$ for the algebraic classes. Our Tate twist is $V(r)^{a,b} = V^{a+r,b+r}$, so that $V(r)$ has weight $\mathrm{wt}(V) - 2r$.

2. REDUCTIONS THAT HOLD FOR EVERY VARIETY

2.1. Correspondences. Let B and X be varieties, possibly disconnected, with B of pure dimension b . For an algebraic cycle Γ of codimension c on $B \times X$ with rational coefficients, the map

$$\Gamma_*: H^k(B, \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^{k+2c-2b}(X, \mathbb{Q}), \quad y \mapsto \mathrm{pr}_{X*}(\mathrm{cl}(\Gamma) \cup \mathrm{pr}_B^* y),$$

is a morphism of Hodge structures $H^k(B)(b-c) \rightarrow H^{k+2c-2b}(X)$. It carries algebraic classes to algebraic classes, the composite of two such maps is the map of the composite correspondence, and for a morphism $f: B \rightarrow X$ the graph Γ_f and its transpose give f_* and f^* [Ful98, Chapter 16]. For a cycle with components of several codimensions we add the maps of the components.

A pure rational Hodge structure V of weight w is *polarizable* if it carries a bilinear form Q such that $Q(Cx, \bar{x}) > 0$ for $x \neq 0$, where C acts on $V^{a,b}$ by i^{a-b} . The cohomology of a

variety and its Tate twists are polarizable, by the Hodge–Riemann relations [Voi02, Chapter 6]. Polarizable Hodge structures are semisimple.²

Lemma 2.1. *Let $\varphi: V \rightarrow W$ be a surjective morphism of polarizable Hodge structures of weight $2p$. Then φ maps the Hodge classes of V , the rational classes of type (p, p) , onto those of W .*

Proof. By semisimplicity the kernel of φ has a complement V' that is a sub-Hodge structure, and φ restricts to an isomorphism of Hodge structures $V' \rightarrow W$. Its inverse carries a Hodge class of W to a Hodge class of $V' \subseteq V$. $\square$

Lemma 2.2 (Dominated cohomology). *Let X be a variety, and let $B_1, \dots, B_r$ be varieties with algebraic cycles Γ_j on $B_j \times X$, such that the images of the maps Γ_{j*} span $H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$. Then every Hodge class of degree $2p$ on X is a sum $\sum_j \Gamma_{j*} \gamma_j$ with γ_j Hodge classes on B_j . In particular, if the Hodge conjecture holds for every B_j , it holds for X in degree $2p$.*

Proof. Write $\Gamma_j = \sum_c \Gamma_{j,c}$ with $\Gamma_{j,c}$ of pure codimension c , and $b_j = \dim B_j$ (if B_j is not equidimensional, treat its components separately). The component $\Gamma_{j,c}$ maps into degree $2p$ exactly from $H^k(B_j)$ with $k = 2p + 2b_j - 2c$, which is even. The sum of the maps

$$\bigoplus_{j,c} H^{2p+2b_j-2c}(B_j, \mathbb{Q})(b_j - c) \longrightarrow H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$$

is a surjective morphism of polarizable Hodge structures of weight $2p$. A Hodge class in $H^{2p+2b_j-2c}(B_j)(b_j - c)$ is a Hodge class of B_j . Apply Lemma 2.1. Algebraic classes go to algebraic classes under correspondences, which gives the last assertion. $\square$

2.2. Degree two and hard Lefschetz.

Theorem 2.3 (Lefschetz [Lef24], Kodaira–Spencer [KS53]). *Every Hodge class of degree two is algebraic.*

Proof. The exponential sequence gives an exact sequence

$$H^1(X, \mathcal{O}_X^\times) \rightarrow H^2(X, \mathbb{Z}) \rightarrow H^2(X, \mathcal{O}_X),$$

whose second map is the composite of $H^2(X, \mathbb{Z}) \rightarrow H^2(X, \mathbb{C})$ with the projection to $H^{0,2}(X)$. An integral class of type $(1, 1)$ therefore is the first Chern class of a holomorphic line bundle, which is algebraic by GAGA, and its first Chern class is the class of a divisor. A rational Hodge class has an integral multiple. $\square$

Let h be the class of a hyperplane section of X , of dimension n , and L the cup product with h . By the hard Lefschetz theorem $L^{n-k}: H^k(X, \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^{2n-k}(X, \mathbb{Q})$ is an isomorphism for $k \leq n$ [Voi02, Theorem 6.25].

Proposition 2.4. *For $2p < n$, if every Hodge class of degree $2p$ on X is algebraic, so is every Hodge class of degree $2n - 2p$. Every Hodge class of degree $0, 2, 2n - 2$ or $2n$ is algebraic, and (HC) holds for every variety of dimension at most three.*

Proof. L^{n-2p} maps $H^{p,p}$ onto $H^{n-p, n-p}$ and rational classes to rational classes, so it maps $\text{Hdg}^p(X)$ onto $\text{Hdg}^{n-p}(X)$; and it maps the class of a subvariety Z to the class of $Z \cap H_1 \cap \dots \cap H_{n-2p}$ for general hyperplanes H_i . Hence $\text{Hdg}^{n-p}(X) = L^{n-2p} \text{Alg}^p(X) \subseteq \text{Alg}^{n-p}(X)$. Degrees 0 and $2n$ are spanned by the fundamental class and the class of a point; degree 2 is Theorem 2.3, and degree $2n - 2$ follows from it. For $n \leq 3$ every even degree is one of these. $\square$

²If $W \subseteq V$ is a sub-Hodge structure, the restriction of Q to W is again a polarization, hence nondegenerate, so $V = W \oplus W^\perp$. The orthogonal $W^\perp$ is a sub-Hodge structure, because the decomposition $V_{\mathbb{C}} = \bigoplus V^{a,b}$ is orthogonal for the hermitian form $Q(Cx, \bar{y})$ and $W_{\mathbb{C}}$ is the sum of its intersections with the $V^{a,b}$.

2.3. Surjective morphisms and blow-ups.

Proposition 2.5. *Let $f: Z \rightarrow X$ be a surjective morphism, with X connected, and let $r = \dim Z - \dim X$. Let h_Z be an ample class on Z , and $d > 0$ the degree of h_Z^r on a general fibre. Then $\alpha = d^{-1}f_*(h_Z^r \cup f^*\alpha)$ for every $\alpha \in H^*(X, \mathbb{Q})$. In particular the correspondence $\Gamma = d^{-1}(h_Z^r \times 1) \cdot \Gamma_f$ from Z to X satisfies $\Gamma_*f^* = \text{id}$, so Γ_* is surjective, and (HC) for Z implies (HC) for X .*

Proof. By the projection formula $f_*(h_Z^r \cup f^*\alpha) = f_*(h_Z^r) \cup \alpha$, and $f_*(h_Z^r) \in H^0(X, \mathbb{Q}) = \mathbb{Q}$ is the degree d , which is positive because h_Z is ample on the fibres. The last claim follows from Lemma 2.2. $\square$

Proposition 2.6. *Let $Y \subseteq X$ be a smooth closed subvariety, possibly disconnected, of codimension $c \geq 2$ in every component, let $\pi: \tilde{X} \rightarrow X$ be the blow-up along Y , let $j: E \rightarrow \tilde{X}$ be the exceptional divisor and $q: E \rightarrow Y$ the projective bundle, and let $\xi = c_1(\mathcal{O}_E(1))$. Then*

$$H^k(\tilde{X}, \mathbb{Q}) = \pi^*H^k(X, \mathbb{Q}) \oplus \bigoplus_{i=0}^{c-2} j_*(\xi^i \cup q^*H^{k-2i-2}(Y, \mathbb{Q})),$$

and each summand is the image of a correspondence: π^* from X , and $y \mapsto j_*(\xi^i \cup q^*y)$ from Y .

Proof. The decomposition is the blow-up formula [Voi02, Theorem 7.31]. The map $y \mapsto j_*(\xi^i \cup q^*y)$ is the correspondence given by the image in $Y \times \tilde{X}$ of a cycle on E representing ξ^i , pushed forward along $(q, j): E \rightarrow Y \times \tilde{X}$. $\square$

2.4. The statements.

Definition 2.7. Let X range over all varieties and p over all integers.

- (1) (F2): the Hodge conjecture for every complex abelian variety.³
- (2) (F3'): $\text{Hdg}^p(X) = \text{Ab}^p(X)$, where $\text{Ab}^p(X)$ is the span of the classes $\Gamma_*\gamma$ of degree $2p$ with B an abelian variety (the point included), γ a Hodge class on B and Γ an algebraic cycle on $B \times X$ [BMB26, Definition 20.34].
- (3) (L): for every X and every ample class on X , the Lefschetz involution $*_L$ defined below is induced by an algebraic cycle on $X \times X$. This is Grothendieck's standard conjecture $B(X)$ for every X [Gro69]: by [Kle68, 1.4.4] and [And96, Proposition 1.2], the $\mathbb{Q}$ -algebra of operators generated by L and $*_L$ is the one generated by L and the operator Λ of $B(X)$.
- (4) (M): every Hodge class is motivated in the sense of [And96, §1].
- (5) (V): for every smooth projective morphism $f: \mathcal{X} \rightarrow S$ over a smooth connected quasi-projective variety, and every global section ξ of $R^{2p}f_*\mathbb{Q}$ over S^{an} , if ξ_s is algebraic for one $s \in S$ then ξ_t is algebraic for every $t \in S$.
- (6) (CM): the Hodge conjecture for every abelian variety of CM type.
- (7) (IP): the case of (V) in which f is a polarized abelian scheme and $\mathcal{X}_s$ is of CM type.

An abelian variety A is of *CM type* if $\text{End}(A) \otimes \mathbb{Q}$ contains a commutative semisimple $\mathbb{Q}$ -algebra of dimension $2 \dim A$; the point is of CM type, and products of abelian varieties of CM type are of CM type.

Each $\Gamma_*\gamma$ in (F3') is a Hodge class, so $\text{Ab}^p(X) \subseteq \text{Hdg}^p(X)$; taking B a point shows that $\text{Ab}^p(X)$ contains $\text{Alg}^p(X)$. Thus (F3') asks only that Hodge classes be algebraic *modulo* what abelian varieties supply. By Proposition 2.5, applied to $A \times \mathbb{P}^1 \rightarrow A$, the conjecture for varieties

³In [BMB26] the name (F2) denotes a statement about the Hodge classes not generated by divisors and Weil classes, and it is proved there to be equivalent to the Hodge conjecture for abelian varieties. We use the simpler form.

that are not abelian already contains the conjecture for abelian varieties; this is why the half of the conjecture that concerns other varieties has to be stated modulo abelian varieties to be a separate problem.

2.5. The Lefschetz standard conjecture and motivated classes. Let X have dimension n and ample class h . Every class in $H^k(X)$ is uniquely $\sum_j L^j x_j$ with x_j primitive of degree $k - 2j$, and the *Lefschetz involution* is defined by $*_L(L^j x_j) = L^{n-k+j} x_j$ [And96, §1.1]. On H^k with $k \leq n$ it is L^{n-k} , and on H^{2n-k} it is the inverse of L^{n-k} . A class $\alpha \in H^{2p}(X, \mathbb{Q})$ is *motivated* [And96, Définition 1] if there are a variety Y , ample classes h_X on X and h_Y on Y , and algebraic classes β, γ on $X \times Y$ with

$$\alpha = \text{pr}_{X*}(\beta \cup *_L \gamma),$$

where $*_L$ is the Lefschetz involution of $X \times Y$ for the ample class $\text{pr}_X^* h_X + \text{pr}_Y^* h_Y$. We use three facts from [And96]. (a) Motivated classes are Hodge classes, they contain the algebraic classes, and they form a graded $\mathbb{Q}$ -algebra that is stable under pull-back and push-forward along projections [And96, Proposition 2.1 and §2.5]; hence a correspondence given by an algebraic cycle maps motivated classes to motivated classes.⁴ (b) Every Hodge class on an abelian variety is motivated [And96, Théorème 0.6.2]. (c) If the Lefschetz involution of every variety, for every ample class, is induced by an algebraic cycle, then every motivated class is algebraic [And96, §2, after Définition 1]. Fact (c) is immediate from the definition: $*_L \gamma$ is then the image of an algebraic class under an algebraic correspondence.

Proposition 2.8. (L) and (M) together imply (HC).

Proof. By (M) every Hodge class is motivated, and by (L) and fact (c) every motivated class is algebraic. $\square$

Proposition 2.9. (F3') implies (M).

Proof. Under (F3') every Hodge class is a sum of classes $\Gamma_* \gamma$ with γ a Hodge class on an abelian variety. Such a γ is motivated by fact (b), and $\Gamma_* \gamma$ is motivated by fact (a). $\square$

2.6. Families.

Lemma 2.10 (Theorem of the fixed part). *Let $f: \mathcal{X} \rightarrow S$ be a smooth projective morphism over a smooth connected quasi-projective variety, and ξ a global section of $R^k f_* \mathbb{Q}$. If ξ_s is a Hodge class for one $s \in S$, then ξ_t is a Hodge class for every $t \in S$.*

Proof. By Deligne's theorem of the fixed part [Del71, Corollaire 4.1.2] the space $H^0(S, R^k f_* \mathbb{Q})$ carries a Hodge structure for which each restriction $r_t: H^0(S, R^k f_* \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^k(\mathcal{X}_t, \mathbb{Q})$ is an injective morphism of Hodge structures.⁵ An injective morphism of Hodge structures that sends a class x to a class of type (p, p) forces x to be of type (p, p) , because it respects the Hodge decompositions. So ξ is a Hodge class of $H^0(S, R^k f_* \mathbb{Q})$, and $\xi_t = r_t(\xi)$ is a Hodge class for every t . $\square$

Lemma 2.11. (HC) implies each of (F2), (F3'), (L), (M), (V), (CM) and (IP).

⁴For a correspondence, $\Gamma_* \gamma = \text{pr}_{X*}(\text{cl}(\Gamma) \cup \text{pr}_B^* \gamma)$ is built from γ by a pull-back along a projection, a product with an algebraic class and a push-forward along a projection.

⁵Injective because a section of a local system over a connected base is determined by its value at one point. The Hodge structure is the image of $H^k(\bar{\mathcal{X}}, \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^k(\mathcal{X}_t, \mathbb{Q})$ for a smooth compactification $\bar{\mathcal{X}}$ of $\mathcal{X}$, which by [Del71, 4.1.1] is the whole invariant part. A global section that is of type (p, q) at one point is of type (p, q) everywhere [Del71, 4.1.3.1].

Proof. (F2) and (CM) are special cases, and (F3') holds because $\text{Ab}^p(X)$ contains $\text{Alg}^p(X)$. For (L): on each $H^k(X)$ the involution $*_L$ is a morphism of Hodge structures $H^k(X) \rightarrow H^{2n-k}(X)(n-k)$, so under the Künneth decomposition and Poincaré duality each of its components is a Hodge class on $X \times X$,⁶ and (HC) makes it algebraic. Algebraic classes are motivated, which gives (M). For (V): if ξ_s is algebraic, it is a Hodge class, so ξ_t is a Hodge class for every t by Lemma 2.10, and (HC) makes it algebraic. (IP) is a case of (V). $\square$

3. FERMAT VARIETIES

3.1. Varieties dominated by CM abelian varieties.

Definition 3.1. Let $\mathcal{D}$ be the class of varieties X , possibly disconnected, such that $H^*(X, \mathbb{Q})$ is spanned by the images of maps $\Gamma_*: H^*(B, \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^*(X, \mathbb{Q})$, where B runs over the abelian varieties of CM type, the point included, and Γ over the algebraic cycles on $B \times X$.

Proposition 3.2. (i) *Every $X \in \mathcal{D}$ satisfies (F3'). If (CM) holds, every $X \in \mathcal{D}$ satisfies (HC).*

(ii) *$\mathcal{D}$ contains every abelian variety of CM type and every finite set of points, and every curve whose Jacobian is of CM type.*

(iii) *$\mathcal{D}$ is closed under finite disjoint unions, under taking connected components, and under products.*

(iv) *If $Z \in \mathcal{D}$ and $f: Z \rightarrow X$ is a surjective morphism, then $X \in \mathcal{D}$.*

(v) *If $X \in \mathcal{D}$ and $Y \subseteq X$ is a smooth closed subvariety of codimension at least two in every component, with $Y \in \mathcal{D}$, then the blow-up of X along Y lies in $\mathcal{D}$.*

Proof. (i) By Lemma 2.2, applied in each degree to finitely many Γ_* whose images span, every Hodge class on X is a sum of classes $\Gamma_*\gamma$ with γ a Hodge class on an abelian variety of CM type. Such a class lies in $\text{Ab}^p(X)$, and under (CM) it is algebraic.

(ii) For B of CM type take Γ the diagonal. For a finite set of points take B a point and Γ the points of X one at a time. For a curve C with Jacobian J of CM type: $H^0(C)$ and $H^2(C)$ are spanned by the fundamental class and the class of a point, which are images from the point, and $H^1(C) = \alpha^*H^1(J)$ for an Abel–Jacobi map $\alpha: C \rightarrow J$, and α^* is the correspondence given by the transpose of the graph of α .

(iii) A disjoint union: the cohomology is the direct sum, and a cycle on $B \times X_i$ is a cycle on $B \times \bigsqcup_i X_i$. A connected component X' of X : restriction $H^*(X) \rightarrow H^*(X')$ is surjective and is the correspondence given by the transpose of the graph of the inclusion, so composing gives correspondences from the B 's onto $H^*(X')$. A product: by the Künneth formula $H^*(X \times X')$ is spanned by the classes $\text{pr}^*x \cup \text{pr}'^*x'$, and if $x = \Gamma_*y$ and $x' = \Gamma'_*y'$ then $\text{pr}^*x \cup \text{pr}'^*x' = \pm(\Gamma \times \Gamma')_*(\text{pr}_B^*y \cup \text{pr}_{B'}^*y')$, where $\Gamma \times \Gamma'$ is a cycle on $(B \times B') \times (X \times X')$ and $B \times B'$ is of CM type.

(iv) By (iii) we may assume X connected and replace Z by a component that maps onto X . By Proposition 2.5 there is a correspondence Γ from Z to X with Γ_* surjective; composing it with the correspondences that dominate $H^*(Z)$ gives correspondences that dominate $H^*(X)$.

(v) By Proposition 2.6 the cohomology of the blow-up is spanned by the images of correspondences from X and from Y ; compose them with the correspondences that dominate $H^*(X)$ and $H^*(Y)$. $\square$

⁶A $\mathbb{Q}$ -linear map $u: H^a(X) \rightarrow H^b(X)$ corresponds to an element of $H^a(X)^\vee \otimes H^b(X) \cong H^{2n-a}(X)(n) \otimes H^b(X)$, a summand of $H^{2n-a+b}(X \times X)(n)$, and the correspondence it defines acts as u . The map u is a morphism of Hodge structures $H^a(X) \rightarrow H^b(X)(r)$ exactly when this element is a Hodge class of the appropriate weight.

3.2. Fermat curves.

Lemma 3.3. *For every $m \geq 1$ the Jacobian of the Fermat curve X_m^1 is of CM type.*

Proof. For $m \leq 2$ the curve is rational and the Jacobian is a point. Let $m \geq 3$, let $g = (m-1)(m-2)/2$ be the genus, and use the affine model $u^m + v^m = 1$, which is isomorphic to X_m^1 over $\mathbb{C}$. The group $G = \mu_m \times \mu_m$ acts by $(\zeta, \zeta') \cdot (u, v) = (\zeta u, \zeta' v)$, and this action extends to the smooth projective curve. The forms

$$\omega_{r,s} = u^{r-1} v^{s-m} du, \quad r, s \geq 1, \quad r + s \leq m-1,$$

are holomorphic⁷, and there are $(m-1)(m-2)/2 = g$ of them, so they form a basis of $H^{1,0}$. The form $\omega_{r,s}$ is an eigenvector of G with character $(\zeta, \zeta') \mapsto \zeta^r \zeta'^s$, and distinct pairs (r, s) give distinct characters, since $1 \leq r, s \leq m-2$. The complex conjugates span $H^{0,1}$ and have the characters $(-r, -s) = (m-r, m-s)$; since $(m-r) + (m-s) \geq m+1$, none of these occurs in $H^{1,0}$. So $H^1(X_m^1, \mathbb{C})$ is the direct sum of $2g$ lines on which G acts by $2g$ distinct characters.

Let $E \subseteq \text{End}(H^1(X_m^1, \mathbb{Q}))$ be the image of the group algebra $\mathbb{Q}[G]$. It is commutative and semisimple, as a quotient of a commutative semisimple algebra, and $E \otimes \mathbb{C}$ is the image of $\mathbb{C}[G]$, which acts on each of the $2g$ lines through its own character; since the characters are distinct, $E \otimes \mathbb{C} \cong \mathbb{C}^{2g}$ and $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} E = 2g$. The elements of G act on the Jacobian, and H^1 of the Jacobian is H^1 of the curve, so $E \subseteq \text{End}(J) \otimes \mathbb{Q}$. Thus J is of CM type. $\square$

The characters can be grouped into orbits of $(\mathbb{Z}/m)^\times$, and each orbit spans the cohomology of an isogeny factor of J with complex multiplication by a quotient of $\mathbb{Q}(\mu_m)$ [KR78]; this is the classical computation of Weil [Wei52].

3.3. The inductive structure. Fix $m \geq 1$ and write $X^n = X_m^n$, the Fermat variety $x_0^m + \dots + x_{n+1}^m = 0$ in $\mathbb{P}^{n+1}$, for $n \geq 0$; thus X^0 is a set of m points. Fix ε with $\varepsilon^m = -1$.

Proposition 3.4 (Shioda–Katsura [SK79]). *Let $r, s \geq 1$, let $Y \subseteq X^r \times X^s$ be the subvariety $x_{r+1} = y_{s+1} = 0$, which is isomorphic to $X^{r-1} \times X^{s-1}$ and has codimension two, and let Z be the blow-up of $X^r \times X^s$ along Y . The rational map $\varphi: X^r \times X^s \dashrightarrow X^{r+s}$,*

$$\varphi(x, y) = [x_0 y_{s+1} : \dots : x_r y_{s+1} : \varepsilon x_{r+1} y_0 : \dots : \varepsilon x_{r+1} y_s],$$

is defined exactly off Y , and it extends to a surjective morphism $Z \rightarrow X^{r+s}$.

Proof. The image lies in X^{r+s} , because $y_{s+1}^m \sum_{i \leq r} x_i^m + \varepsilon^m x_{r+1}^m \sum_{j \leq s} y_j^m = -y_{s+1}^m x_{r+1}^m + x_{r+1}^m y_{s+1}^m = 0$. All coordinates vanish exactly on Y : if $y_{s+1} \neq 0$ they force $x_0 = \dots = x_r = 0$ and then $x_{r+1}^m = -\sum_{i \leq r} x_i^m = 0$, which is impossible; so $y_{s+1} = 0$, and in the same way $x_{r+1} = 0$. On the blow-up, on the chart where $y_{s+1} = t x_{r+1}$, the map is $[tx_0 : \dots : tx_r : \varepsilon y_0 : \dots : \varepsilon y_s]$; here $y_0, \dots, y_s$ do not all vanish, because otherwise $y_{s+1}^m = 0$ as well. The other chart is symmetric. So φ extends to a morphism on Z [SK79, Lemma 1.2]. It is dominant, since from a general point of X^{r+s} one recovers $[x_0 : \dots : x_r]$ and $[y_0 : \dots : y_s]$, and then x_{r+1} and y_{s+1} up to finitely many choices; its image is closed and X^{r+s} is irreducible for $r + s \geq 2$, so it is surjective.⁸ $\square$

⁷On the affine curve $v^{s-m} du = -v^{s-1} u^{1-m} dv$ shows that $\omega_{r,s}$ has no poles where u or v is finite. At the m points at infinity, u and v have simple poles and du has a double pole, so $\omega_{r,s}$ has order $-(r-1) - (s-m) - 2 = m-1-r-s \geq 0$ there.

⁸Shioda and Katsura show more: the morphism $Z \rightarrow X^{r+s}$ is the composite of the quotient by a cyclic group of order m and a birational morphism that contracts two disjoint subvarieties of the quotient [SK79, Theorem 1.7]. We use only that it is a surjective morphism.

3.4. Proof of Theorem C.

Theorem 3.5. *Every Fermat variety X_m^n lies in $\mathcal{D}$. So do all products of Fermat varieties of any degrees and dimensions, and every variety onto which such a product maps surjectively.*

Proof. Fix m . We show $X^n \in \mathcal{D}$ by induction on n . The set of points X^0 lies in $\mathcal{D}$, and so does the curve X^1 , by Proposition 3.2(ii) and Lemma 3.3. Let $n \geq 2$ and suppose $X^k \in \mathcal{D}$ for $k < n$. Apply Proposition 3.4 with $r = 1$ and $s = n - 1$. The product $X^1 \times X^{n-1}$ and the centre $Y \cong X^0 \times X^{n-2}$ lie in $\mathcal{D}$ by Proposition 3.2(iii); the blow-up Z lies in $\mathcal{D}$ by Proposition 3.2(v); and X^n , the image of Z , lies in $\mathcal{D}$ by Proposition 3.2(iv). The remaining assertions are Proposition 3.2(iii) and (iv). $\square$

Proof of Theorem C. Combine Theorem 3.5 with Proposition 3.2(i). $\square$

The proof shows more than Theorem C states: every Hodge class on a Fermat variety is the image, under an explicit algebraic correspondence, of a Hodge class on a power of the Jacobians of Fermat curves of the same degree. Theorem C is therefore exactly as strong as (CM) for these powers.

3.5. The Hodge classes of a Fermat variety. The group $G_n = \mu_m^{n+2}/\mu_m$ acts on X_m^n by multiplying the coordinates, and its characters are the vectors $a = (a_0, \dots, a_{n+1}) \in (\mathbb{Z}/m)^{n+2}$ with $\sum a_i = 0$. Let $\mathfrak{A}_m^n$ be the set of characters with every $a_i \neq 0$. For $a \in \mathfrak{A}_m^n$ write $\langle a \rangle = \sum_i \bar{a}_i/m$, where $\bar{a}_i \in \{1, \dots, m-1\}$ represents a_i ; it is an integer between 1 and $n+1$.

Proposition 3.6. (i) *The primitive cohomology $H_{\text{prim}}^n(X_m^n, \mathbb{C})$ is the direct sum of lines $V(a)$, one for each $a \in \mathfrak{A}_m^n$, on which G_n acts by pull-back through the character a ; and $V(a) \subseteq H^{n-q,q}$ with $q = \langle a \rangle - 1$. Hence*

$$\dim H_{\text{prim}}^n = |\mathfrak{A}_m^n| = \frac{(m-1)^{n+2} + (-1)^n(m-1)}{m}, \quad h_{\text{prim}}^{n-q,q} = \#\{a : \langle a \rangle = q+1\}.$$

(ii) *Let n be even. The space of primitive Hodge classes, tensored with $\mathbb{C}$, is the sum of the lines $V(a)$ for which $\langle ta \rangle = n/2 + 1$ for every $t \in (\mathbb{Z}/m)^\times$.*

Proof. (i) By Griffiths' description of the cohomology of a hypersurface by residues [Gri69, §8], $H_{\text{prim}}^{n-q,q}(X_m^n)$ is isomorphic to the graded piece of degree $(q+1)m - (n+2)$ of the Jacobian ring $\mathbb{C}[x_0, \dots, x_{n+1}]/(x_0^{m-1}, \dots, x_{n+1}^{m-1})$, the class of a monomial x^b corresponding to the residue of $x^b \Omega / F^{q+1}$, where $F = \sum x_i^m$ and $\Omega = \sum (-1)^i x_i dx_0 \wedge \dots \wedge \widehat{dx_i} \wedge \dots \wedge dx_{n+1}$. That residue is an eigenvector of G_n with character $a = b + (1, \dots, 1)$, because Ω has character $(1, \dots, 1)$ and F is invariant. As b runs over the exponents with $0 \leq b_i \leq m-2$, the vector a runs once over the characters with $1 \leq \bar{a}_i \leq m-1$; the degree condition is $\sum \bar{a}_i = (q+1)m$, that is, $\langle a \rangle = q+1$, and it forces $\sum a_i = 0$ in $\mathbb{Z}/m$. The count of $\mathfrak{A}_m^n$ follows from the recursion $N_k = (m-1)^{k-1} - N_{k-1}$, $N_1 = 0$, for the number N_k of k -tuples of nonzero residues with sum zero.

(ii) The eigenspace decomposition is defined over $\mathbb{Q}(\mu_m)$, and the automorphism $\zeta \mapsto \zeta^t$ of $\mathbb{Q}(\mu_m)$ carries $V(a)$ to $V(ta)$. So for each orbit O of $(\mathbb{Z}/m)^\times$ on $\mathfrak{A}_m^n$ the sum $\bigoplus_{a \in O} V(a)$ is defined over $\mathbb{Q}$, these rational subspaces decompose $H_{\text{prim}}^n(X_m^n, \mathbb{Q})$, and the one for O consists of Hodge classes exactly when every $V(a)$, $a \in O$, has type $(n/2, n/2)$, that is, when $\langle a \rangle = n/2 + 1$ on O . A rational class with a component on some $V(a)$ has components on the whole orbit of a , so the Hodge classes are the sum of the rational subspaces of the orbits of this kind. $\square$

For a Fermat surface the Picard number is $\rho(X_m^2) = 1 + \#\{a \in \mathfrak{A}_m^2 : \langle ta \rangle = 2 \text{ for all } t \in (\mathbb{Z}/m)^\times\}$, and $h^{1,1} = (2m^3 - 6m^2 + 7m)/3$. Figure 2 compares the two for $m \leq 12$. For m prime to 6, $\rho = 3(m-1)(m-2) + 1$, and the Néron–Severi group is spanned by the $3m^2$ lines on the surface [AS83]; the quartic, quintic and sextic give $\rho = 20, 37$ and 86 .

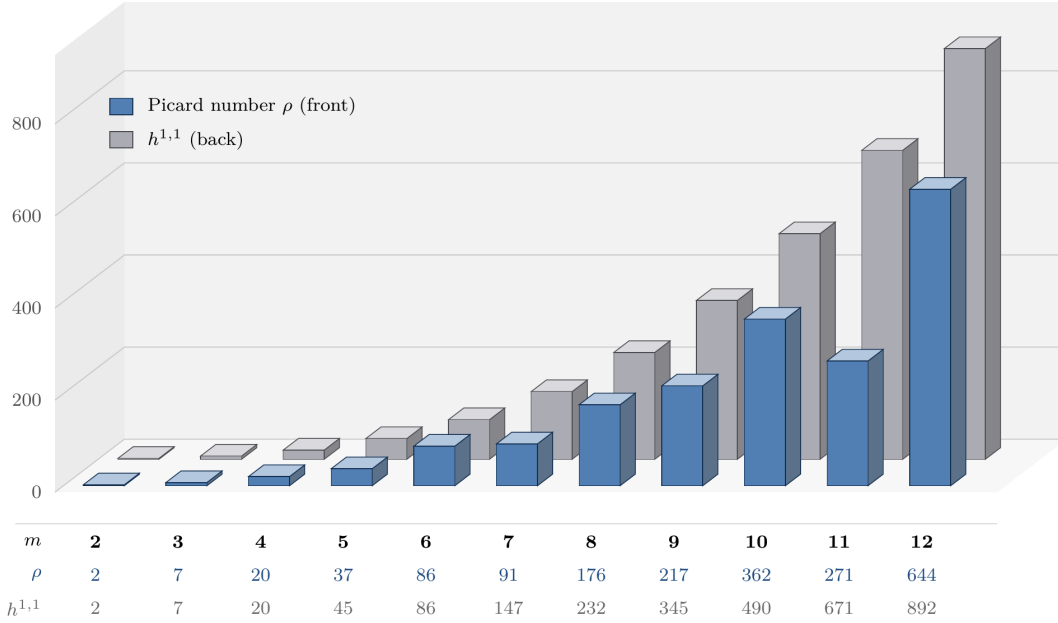


FIGURE 2. The Fermat surfaces X_m^2 , $2 \leq m \leq 12$: the Picard number ρ (front row) against $h^{1,1}$ (back row), both computed from Proposition 3.6. On a surface every Hodge class is algebraic (Theorem 2.3); the figure shows how the share of $H^{1,1}$ that is defined over $\mathbb{Q}$ varies with the arithmetic of m . The values of $h^{1,1}$ are recomputed from the Jacobian ring in Macaulay2 (Appendix A).

Remark 3.7. The Hodge conjecture for X_m^n is known without hypothesis when m is prime or $m = 4$ [Ran80, Shi79], when $m \leq 20$ [Shi79], and when m is the square of a prime (Aoki); see [dSJ21, §2] for precise statements. Further cases are proved in [dSJ21], and a computer-assisted proof for Fermat fourfolds of odd degree at most 199 is given in the preprint [Jum26]. In these proofs the Hodge classes are written as combinations of the classes of linear subspaces and of cycles built from them, characters a that split into pairs $a_i + a_j = 0$ corresponding to linear subspaces. Theorem C needs no such decomposition: it moves the whole question to the Jacobians of Fermat curves. The preprint [Ope26a] announces the Hodge conjecture on every self-power of a very general member of the family of diagonal hypersurfaces; the Fermat varieties are special members of that family.

4. ABELIAN VARIETIES: CM POINTS AND PROPAGATION

4.1. The statement (CM). Let A be an abelian variety of CM type. Its Hodge group is a torus, and after extending scalars to a Galois CM field E that splits it, $H^1(A)$ is a sum of lines indexed by embeddings, each of type $(1, 0)$ or $(0, 1)$. Deligne and André showed that every Hodge class on A is a sum of pull-backs, along homomorphisms $A \rightarrow A_\Delta$, of Weil classes on abelian varieties A_Δ of split Weil type [Mil20, Theorem 1]. So (CM) is equivalent to the algebraicity of these split Weil classes, and it is open in the refereed literature.

The preprint [Ope26b] claims (CM) [Ope26b, Theorem 1.1]. Its proof has four steps. (1) The theorem is reduced [Ope26b, Proposition 2.6] to the algebraicity of a line of type $(2, 2)$ on a product of four CM abelian varieties $B(v_1), \dots, B(v_4)$, attached to odd sign functions $v_i: \text{Gal}(E/\mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow \{\pm 1\}$ with $v_1 + v_2 = v_3 + v_4$ [Ope26b, Theorem 2.5]. (2) That line is shown

to be algebraic as soon as four degree-one classes on a surface, coming from the four CM Hodge structures, have a nonzero mixed period [Ope26b, Proposition 3.1]. (3) Such a period is produced by theta forms on compact quotients of the complex two-ball [Ope26b, §4]. (4) The theta classes are shown to come from the prescribed CM Hodge structures, through Hecke operators and a Frobenius relation on the reductions of the ball quotients [Ope26b, Theorem 5.1 and Corollary 6.7].

We have checked the combinatorial part of step (1): its core is Lemma 4.1 below, and its contraction formula [Ope26b, (2.6)] carries the sign $(-1)^{p(p-1)/2}$, which we recompute in Appendix A. We have not checked steps (2) to (4), and the claim rests on step (4). Accordingly, every result of this paper that uses (CM) states it as a hypothesis.

Lemma 4.1 (Two-row switches). *Let G be a finite set with a fixed-point-free involution c , let $s = |G|/2$, and call $v: G \rightarrow \{\pm 1\}$ odd if $v(cg) = -v(g)$. Let $x = (x_1, \dots, x_p)$ and $y = (y_1, \dots, y_p)$ be lists of odd functions with $\sum_i x_i = \sum_i y_i$. Then there is a chain of lists of odd functions $x = x^{(0)}, x^{(1)}, \dots, x^{(N)} = y$ with $N \leq s\lfloor p/2 \rfloor$, in which $x^{(k+1)}$ differs from $x^{(k)}$ in exactly two entries $i \neq j$, and $x_i^{(k+1)} + x_j^{(k+1)} = x_i^{(k)} + x_j^{(k)}$.*

Proof. Choose a set T of representatives of the orbits of c ; an odd function is determined by its values on T . Treat the elements $\tau \in T$ one at a time. Let P_τ be the set of indices i with $x_i(\tau) = 1$ and $y_i(\tau) = -1$, and N_τ the set with $x_i(\tau) = -1$ and $y_i(\tau) = 1$. Then $\sum_i x_i(\tau) - \sum_i y_i(\tau) = 2|P_\tau| - 2|N_\tau|$, so $|P_\tau| = |N_\tau| \leq \lfloor p/2 \rfloor$. Pair the two sets, and for each pair (i, j) exchange the values of the i -th and j -th functions at τ and at $c\tau$. Each exchange keeps the functions odd, changes exactly the entries i and j , and keeps their sum, since it only swaps two values at each of two points. After the pairs for τ are exchanged, the list agrees with y at τ and $c\tau$, and the later steps do not change these values. $\square$

In [Ope26b] the lists come from the types of the factors of a Hodge monomial, a two-row switch is exactly a relation $v_1 + v_2 = v_3 + v_4$, and the algebraic tensors of consecutive switches are composed by contracting the middle factors against an ample class [Ope26b, (2.6)].⁹ Nothing in this combinatorial part depends on the geometry of steps (2) to (4).

4.2. Propagation from CM points.

Lemma 4.2 (CM points are dense). *Let G be a connected reductive group over $\mathbb{Q}$, let $u_0: \mathrm{U}(1) \rightarrow G_{\mathbb{R}}$ be a homomorphism, and let $\mathcal{D}$ be its orbit under conjugation by $G(\mathbb{R})^+$. The points $u \in \mathcal{D}$ with $u(\mathrm{U}(1)) \subseteq T_{\mathbb{R}}$ for a maximal torus T of G defined over $\mathbb{Q}$ are dense in $\mathcal{D}$.*

Proof. Let $u_1 \in \mathcal{D}$ and let W be a neighbourhood of u_1 . A maximal torus T_1 of $G_{\mathbb{R}}$ contains the torus $u_1(\mathrm{U}(1))$; let $\mathfrak{t}_1$ be its Lie algebra and $Y_1 \in \mathfrak{t}_1$ a regular element. The map $\phi: G(\mathbb{R})^+ \times \mathfrak{t}_1 \rightarrow \mathfrak{g}_{\mathbb{R}}, (g, Y) \mapsto \mathrm{Ad}(g)Y$, has differential $(Z, Y') \mapsto [Z, Y_1] + Y'$ at $(1, Y_1)$, which is onto because $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathbb{R}} = \mathfrak{t}_1 \oplus [\mathfrak{g}_{\mathbb{R}}, Y_1]$ for a regular semisimple Y_1 . So for small neighbourhoods N_1 of 1, with $N_1 u_1 N_1^{-1} \subseteq W$, and N_2 of Y_1 consisting of regular elements, $\phi(N_1 \times N_2)$ contains a nonempty open set, and hence a rational element $Y = \mathrm{Ad}(g)Y'$ with $g \in N_1$, $Y' \in N_2$. The identity component T of the centralizer of Y is a maximal torus defined over $\mathbb{Q}$, and $T_{\mathbb{R}} = gT_1 g^{-1}$. Then $u = g u_1 g^{-1} \in W$ and $u(\mathrm{U}(1)) \subseteq T_{\mathbb{R}}$. $\square$

⁹The contraction multiplies by $(-1)^{p(p-1)/2} \prod_i q_i$, where the sign comes from regrouping $\beta_1 \cdots \beta_p \gamma_1 \cdots \gamma_p$ as $\beta_1 \gamma_1 \cdots \beta_p \gamma_p$ for classes of degree one, and $q_i = \int_{B(b_i)} \beta_i \wedge \gamma_i \wedge \ell_i^{s-1}$ is nonzero by the Hodge–Riemann relations, because γ_i is a nonzero multiple of $\bar{\beta}_i$.

Proposition 4.3 (A CM member through every Hodge class). *Let A_0 be an abelian variety and γ a Hodge class of degree $2p$ on A_0 . There are a polarized abelian scheme $\pi: \mathcal{A} \rightarrow S$ over a smooth connected quasi-projective variety, a global section ξ of $R^{2p}\pi_*\mathbb{Q}$, and points $s_0, c \in S$, such that $\mathcal{A}_{s_0} \cong A_0$ with $\xi_{s_0} = \gamma$, ξ_s is a Hodge class for every s , and $\mathcal{A}_c$ is of CM type.*

Proof. Replacing γ by a multiple, we may assume it integral. Fix a polarization of A_0 with form ψ on $V = H_1(A_0, \mathbb{Q})$, and a level $N \geq 3$. The complex structures J on $V_{\mathbb{R}}$ that are compatible with ψ and positive for it form the Siegel space $\mathcal{H}$, and its quotient $\mathcal{S}$ by the principal congruence subgroup of level N in $\mathrm{Sp}(H_1(A_0, \mathbb{Z}), \psi)$ is a smooth quasi-projective variety with a universal polarized abelian scheme $f: \mathcal{A}_g \rightarrow \mathcal{S}$ [MFK94, Chapter 7]. Let $\mathbb{V} = R^{2p}f_*\mathbb{Z}$. By the theorem of Cattani, Deligne and Kaplan [CDK95, Theorem 1.1], the set of pairs (a, v) , with $a \in \mathcal{S}$ and $v \in \mathbb{V}_a$ an integral Hodge class with the same self-intersection as γ , is a closed algebraic subvariety of the total space of the vector bundle $\mathbb{V} \otimes \mathcal{O}_{\mathcal{S}}$, finite over $\mathcal{S}$; let $\mathcal{C}$ be its connected component through the point (a_0, γ) given by A_0 and a lift $J_0 \in \mathcal{H}$.

Let $G \subseteq \mathrm{Sp}(V, \psi)$ be the Hodge group of A_0 , the smallest algebraic subgroup over $\mathbb{Q}$ whose real points contain the image of the homomorphism $u_0: \mathrm{U}(1) \rightarrow \mathrm{GL}(V_{\mathbb{R}})$, $e^{i\theta} \mapsto \cos \theta + J_0 \sin \theta$. It is connected and reductive, and it fixes every Hodge class of A_0 , in particular γ [Del82, §3]. For $g \in G(\mathbb{R})^+$ the structure $J = gJ_0g^{-1}$ lies in $\mathcal{H}$, and the Hodge group of A_J is contained in G , so γ is a Hodge class on A_J . The orbit $\mathcal{D} = \{gJ_0g^{-1}\}$ is connected, so its image $J \mapsto (A_J, \gamma)$ lies in $\mathcal{C}$. By Lemma 4.2 there are $J_k \in \mathcal{D}$ converging to J_0 such that $u_{J_k}(\mathrm{U}(1))$ lies in a torus defined over $\mathbb{Q}$; the Hodge group of A_{J_k} is then commutative, and A_{J_k} is of CM type.¹⁰ One of the finitely many irreducible components of $\mathcal{C}$, say $\mathcal{C}_0$, contains infinitely many of the points (a_{J_k}, γ) , and, being closed, also their limit (a_0, γ) .

Let $S \rightarrow \mathcal{C}_0$ be a resolution of singularities [Hir64], so that S is smooth, connected and quasi-projective, and let $\mathcal{A} \rightarrow S$ be the pull-back of $\mathcal{A}_g$. The total space of a local system is a covering space of the base, so $(a, v) \mapsto v$ is a flat section on $\mathcal{C}_0$, and its pull-back is a global section ξ of $R^{2p}\pi_*\mathbb{Z}$ that is a Hodge class at every point. Take s_0 over (a_0, γ) and c over some (a_{J_k}, γ) . $\square$

Proposition 4.4. (F2) holds if and only if both (CM) and (IP) hold.

Proof. (F2) contains (CM), and it implies (IP): if ξ_c is algebraic, then every ξ_s is a Hodge class by Lemma 2.10, hence algebraic. Conversely, let γ be a Hodge class on an abelian variety A_0 , and take π, ξ, s_0 and c from Proposition 4.3. Then ξ_c is a Hodge class on an abelian variety of CM type, so it is algebraic by (CM), and by (IP) the class $\gamma = \xi_{s_0}$ is algebraic. $\square$

The proposition separates the two inputs of the argument of Deligne and André as Milne records it [Mil20, §5]: the classes at CM points, and their transport along families. The variational conjecture (V) supplies both at once [Mil20, Theorem 3 and Remark 2], because the split Weil classes are algebraic at a suitable member of each family [Del82, 4.8]. (IP) supplies only the transport, and it does so only from CM members.

4.3. Proof of Theorem A. By Lemma 2.11, (i) implies each of (ii)–(vi). If (F2) holds, every γ in the definition of $\mathrm{Ab}^p(X)$ is algebraic, so $\mathrm{Ab}^p(X) = \mathrm{Alg}^p(X)$, and (F3') becomes (HC); so (ii) implies (i). (L) implies (F2) by the theorem of Abdulali and André [Mil20, Theorem 4]¹¹,

¹⁰The torus T lies in a maximal torus T' of $\mathrm{GL}(V)$ over $\mathbb{Q}$, the units of a commutative semisimple subalgebra $L \subseteq \mathrm{End}(V)$ of dimension $2g$. Since L commutes with $T' \supseteq \mathrm{Hg}(A_{J_k})$, it lies in the commutant of the Hodge group, which is $\mathrm{End}(A_{J_k}) \otimes \mathbb{Q}$.

¹¹Milne's hypothesis is the Lefschetz standard conjecture in the form that L^{d-2i} maps the algebraic classes of degree $2i$ onto those of degree $2d - 2i$. It follows from (L), since the inverse of L^{d-2i} is then induced by an algebraic cycle and maps algebraic classes to algebraic classes.

(V) implies (F2) [Mil20, Theorem 3 and Remark 2], and (CM) with (IP) implies (F2) by Proposition 4.4; so (iii), (iv) and (v) imply (ii). Finally (vi) implies (i) by Proposition 2.8. $\square$

4.4. Weil families and degrees at CM points. Let K be an imaginary quadratic field and $n \geq 1$. An abelian variety A of dimension $2n$ with an action of K is *of Weil type* if both embeddings of K occur with multiplicity n on $H^{1,0}(A)$. Then the *Weil plane* $W(A) = \bigwedge_K^{2n} H^1(A, \mathbb{Q}) \subseteq H^{2n}(A, \mathbb{Q})$ is a $\mathbb{Q}$ -plane of Hodge classes [Wei79], [Del82, §4]. For a polarization whose Rosati involution induces complex conjugation on K , the Riemann form is $\text{Tr}_{K/\mathbb{Q}}(fH)$ for a K -hermitian form H of signature (n, n) , and A is *of split Weil type* if H has a totally isotropic K -subspace of dimension n [Mil20, §2.1].

Fix such data and a level $N \geq 3$. The abelian varieties of split Weil type for (K, n) with this hermitian form and level structure are parametrized by a smooth connected quasi-projective variety S , a quotient $\Gamma \backslash \mathcal{D}$ of the hermitian symmetric domain $\mathcal{D}$ of $\text{SU}(n, n)$, of dimension n^2 , by a neat arithmetic subgroup Γ of the unitary group; it is a connected Shimura variety of PEL type and carries a polarized abelian scheme $\pi: \mathcal{A} \rightarrow S$ with an action of $\mathcal{O}_K$ [Wei79, vG94].¹² The special points of S are the members of CM type. Fix a nonzero global section ξ of the Weil planes. An element $\alpha \in \mathcal{O}_K$ acts on $\mathcal{A}_s$, and its pull-back multiplies the K -line $W(\mathcal{A}_s)$ by α^{2n} . Choose α with $\alpha^{2n} \notin \mathbb{Q}$.¹³ Then α^* moves any nonzero class of $W(\mathcal{A}_s)$ to a class that spans $W(\mathcal{A}_s)$ with it, and pull-back by an endomorphism preserves algebraic classes; so $W(\mathcal{A}_s)$ consists of algebraic classes exactly when ξ_s is algebraic.

Definition 4.5. Let $\Sigma \subseteq S$ be the set of s at which ξ_s is algebraic. For $d \geq 1$ let Σ_d be the set of s for which there are effective algebraic cycles Z^+, Z^- of codimension n on $\mathcal{A}_s$, each of degree at most d for the polarization, and an integer $1 \leq e \leq d$, with $e\xi_s = \text{cl}(Z^+) - \text{cl}(Z^-)$.

Lemma 4.6. *Each Σ_d is Zariski closed in S , $\Sigma_d \subseteq \Sigma_{d+1}$, and $\Sigma = \bigcup_d \Sigma_d$.*

Proof. The last two assertions are clear. Effective cycles of codimension n and degree at most d in the fibres of π are parametrized by finitely many relative Chow varieties $\mathcal{C}_i \rightarrow S$, which are projective over S [Kol96, Chapter I, §§3–4]. On a connected component of $\mathcal{C}_i \times_S \mathcal{C}_j$ the class $\text{cl}(Z^+) - \text{cl}(Z^-)$ of the fibre is a flat section of the pulled-back local system, and so is $e\xi$. Two flat sections over a connected base that agree at one point agree everywhere, so the set where they agree is a union of connected components. Its image in S is closed, because the projection is proper. Σ_d is the union of finitely many such images. $\square$

Proof of Theorem D. The first sentence is Lemma 4.6. (ii) implies (i) trivially. If (i) holds, S^{an} is the countable union of the closed sets Σ_d , so by the Baire category theorem one of them has an interior point; a Zariski closed subset of the irreducible variety S with an interior point is S , which gives (ii). If (ii) holds, the CM points in $\Sigma_d = S$ are dense in S^{an} by Lemma 4.2, so they lie in no finite union of proper closed subvarieties, which gives (iii). Assume (iii), and let Z be the Zariski closure of the set of CM points in Σ_d ; it lies in Σ_d . Every irreducible component of Z contains a Zariski dense set of special points, so it is a special subvariety, by the André–Oort conjecture, which is a theorem [PST21]. By (iii) one of these components is not proper, so $S \subseteq Z \subseteq \Sigma_d$, which is (ii). Finally, at a CM point ξ_s is a Hodge class on an abelian variety of CM type, so under (CM) it is algebraic. $\square$

¹²The unitary group acts on the Weil plane through the determinant. For $\gamma \in \Gamma$ the determinant is a unit of $\mathcal{O}_K$ of norm one, hence a root of unity, and it is 1 because Γ is neat. So the Weil planes of the members form a trivial local system on S , and every Weil class on one member extends to a global section.

¹³The $\alpha \in K \otimes \mathbb{R} = \mathbb{C}$ with α^{2n} real lie on $2n$ lines through 0, and the lattice $\mathcal{O}_K$ is not contained in finitely many lines.

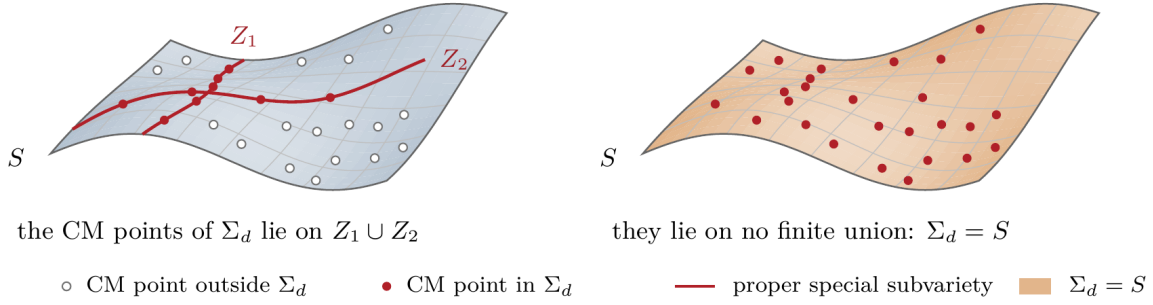


FIGURE 3. The criterion of Theorem D, drawn schematically (S has dimension n^2). CM points are dense in S . On the left the CM points of Σ_d lie on two proper special subvarieties Z_1 and Z_2 , and condition (iii) fails for this d . On the right they lie on no finite union of proper special subvarieties; by the André–Oort theorem their Zariski closure is then S , and $\Sigma_d = S$.

Remark 4.7. Without any hypothesis Σ is dense. It contains the members K -isogenous to $E^n \times \bar{E}^n$, which is of split Weil type and whose Weil classes are polynomials in divisor classes (Lemma 5.10); and with every point it contains its Hecke orbit, which is dense. Algebraic representatives move along isogenies by push-forward and pull-back, and their degree grows with the degree of the isogeny. (CM) adds every CM point, but it gives no bound on the degrees, and by Theorem D a bound on a set of CM points that is not trapped in finitely many proper Shimura subvarieties is exactly what remains. Neither [Ope26b] nor any other source we know gives such a bound.

5. WEIL CLASSES AND SCHOEN'S SUBVARIETY

In this section K is an imaginary quadratic field with a fixed embedding $\chi: K \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ and its conjugate $\bar{\chi}$. Let A be an abelian variety of Weil type for K of dimension $2n$ (Section 4.4) on which $\mathcal{O}_K$ acts, with a polarization class η whose Rosati involution induces complex conjugation on K . Endomorphisms act on cohomology by pull-back, which makes $V = H^1(A, \mathbb{Q})$ a K -vector space of dimension $2n$, and

$$V_{\mathbb{C}} = V \otimes_{\mathbb{Q}} \mathbb{C} = V_{\chi} \oplus V_{\bar{\chi}},$$

where $\alpha \in K$ acts on V_{χ} by $\chi(\alpha)$ and on $V_{\bar{\chi}}$ by $\bar{\chi}(\alpha)$. Each summand has dimension $2n$ and, because A is of Weil type, meets $H^{1,0}$ and $H^{0,1}$ in subspaces of dimension n . The Weil plane satisfies

$$W(A) \otimes \mathbb{C} = \bigwedge^{2n} V_{\chi} \oplus \bigwedge^{2n} V_{\bar{\chi}} \subseteq H^{2n}(A, \mathbb{C})$$

[Del82, §4], and both lines are of type (n, n) . We call A *Weil-algebraic* if every class in $W(A)$ is algebraic. Two facts are used repeatedly. First, an endomorphism $\alpha \in \mathcal{O}_K$ multiplies η by the norm $N(\alpha) = \chi(\alpha)\bar{\chi}(\alpha)$, since its Rosati adjoint is $\bar{\alpha}$; comparing with the action of α on $\bigwedge^2 V_{\mathbb{C}} = \bigwedge^2 V_{\chi} \oplus (V_{\chi} \otimes V_{\bar{\chi}}) \oplus \bigwedge^2 V_{\bar{\chi}}$ for any $\alpha \notin \mathbb{Q}$ shows that $\eta \in V_{\chi} \otimes V_{\bar{\chi}}$, and hence

$$(1) \quad \eta^k \in \bigwedge^k V_{\chi} \otimes \bigwedge^k V_{\bar{\chi}}.$$

Second, if $W(A)$ contains one nonzero algebraic class, then A is Weil-algebraic, by the argument given for ξ_s in Section 4.4.

The Hodge group $\text{Hg}(A)$ commutes with K and preserves the Riemann form, so it lies in the unitary group $\text{U}(V, H)$ of the hermitian form H of the polarization. It fixes the Hodge classes

in $W(A)$, on which $U(V, H)$ acts through the determinant, so $\text{Hg}(A) \subseteq \text{SU}(V, H)$. We say that A has *maximal Hodge group* if equality holds.

5.1. The Hodge ring of a general member.

Proposition 5.1. *If $\text{Hg}(A) = \text{SU}(V, H)$, then $\text{Hdg}^k(A) = \mathbb{Q}\eta^k$ for $k \neq n$, and*

$$\text{Hdg}^n(A) = \mathbb{Q}\eta^n \oplus W(A).$$

Moreover $\eta^n \cup w = 0$ for every $w \in W(A)$.

Proof. The Hodge classes in $H^{2k}(A, \mathbb{Q}) = \Lambda^{2k} V$ are the invariants of $\text{Hg}(A)$ [Del82, §3]. Over $\mathbb{C}$ the group $\text{SU}(V, H)$ becomes $\text{SL}(V_\chi)$, acting on V_χ by the standard representation and on $V_{\bar{\chi}}$ by its dual, because the Riemann form pairs $V_{\bar{\chi}}$ perfectly with V_χ . The invariants in

$$\Lambda^{2k} V_{\mathbb{C}} = \bigoplus_{a+b=2k} \Lambda^a V_\chi \otimes \Lambda^b V_{\bar{\chi}}^\vee = \bigoplus_{a+b=2k} \text{Hom}(\Lambda^b V_\chi, \Lambda^a V_\chi)$$

form a line in each summand with $a = b$ or $\{a, b\} = \{0, 2n\}$, and vanish in the others, because the representations $\Lambda^a V_\chi$, $0 \leq a \leq 2n$, are irreducible and pairwise non-isomorphic except for $\Lambda^0 \cong \Lambda^{2n}$.¹⁴ By (1) the line for $a = b = k$ contains η^k , which is nonzero for $k \leq 2n$ because η^{2n} is a positive multiple of the orientation class. In degree $2n$ the two remaining lines span $W(A) \otimes \mathbb{C}$. This proves the first two assertions. By (1), $\eta^n \cup \Lambda^{2n} V_\chi$ lies in $\Lambda^{3n} V_\chi \otimes \Lambda^n V_{\bar{\chi}} = 0$, and likewise for $V_{\bar{\chi}}$. $\square$

5.2. What is known. For $n = 1$ the Weil plane lies in H^2 and Theorem 2.3 applies. For $n = 2$ the hermitian form is split exactly when its discriminant is trivial, and Floccari and Fu prove that the Weil classes of every Weil fourfold of discriminant one are algebraic [FF26]. Schoen proves algebraicity for the Weil fourfolds of trivial discriminant for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ and for the Weil sixfolds of a family for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ in which his Prym varieties are dense [Sch88, Sch98], and for further families of fourfolds [Sch98]; Koike treats families for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-1})$ built in the same way [Koi04]. Markman's preprint proves algebraicity for every Weil fourfold and every split Weil sixfold [Mar25a]. Since the Hodge ring of an abelian variety of dimension at most five is generated by divisor classes and the Weil classes of its quotients [MZ99], the fourfold case gives (F2) in dimension at most five. For $2n \geq 8$ we know of no family of Weil type whose general member has maximal Hodge group and on which the Weil classes are known to be algebraic at every member.

5.3. Semiregularity. Let Z be a smooth projective variety of dimension N and $\mathcal{E}$ a coherent sheaf on Z , with Atiyah class $\text{at}(\mathcal{E}) \in \text{Ext}^1(\mathcal{E}, \mathcal{E} \otimes \Omega_Z^1)$. The *semiregularity map* of Buchweitz and Flenner is

$$\sigma_{\mathcal{E}}: \text{Ext}^2(\mathcal{E}, \mathcal{E}) \longrightarrow \bigoplus_{q=0}^{N-2} H^{q+2}(Z, \Omega_Z^q), \quad e \longmapsto \left(\text{tr}(\text{at}(\mathcal{E})^q \circ e) / q! \right)_q,$$

and $\mathcal{E}$ is *semiregular* if $\sigma_{\mathcal{E}}$ is injective [BF03]. A subvariety $Y \subseteq Z$ is semiregular if $\mathcal{O}_Y$ is.¹⁵ The point of the definition is the following theorem. If an infinitesimal deformation of Z keeps $\text{ch}(\mathcal{E})$ of Hodge type, the obstruction to deforming $\mathcal{E}$ along it is sent by $\sigma_{\mathcal{E}}$ to the obstruction for $\text{ch}(\mathcal{E})$ to stay of Hodge type, which vanishes; injectivity of $\sigma_{\mathcal{E}}$ then kills the first obstruction.

¹⁴The representation Λ^a of SL_{2n} is irreducible with highest weight the a -th fundamental weight for $1 \leq a \leq 2n - 1$, and these weights are distinct; Λ^0 and Λ^{2n} are trivial.

¹⁵Bloch introduced semiregularity for local complete intersection subvarieties, through a map $H^1(Y, N_{Y/Z}) \rightarrow H^{p+1}(Z, \Omega_Z^{p-1})$ in codimension p , and proved the deformation theorem below in that setting [Blo72]. Buchweitz and Flenner extend both the map and the theorem to coherent sheaves.

Theorem 5.2 (Buchweitz–Flenner [BF03, Theorem 1.5], after Bloch [Blo72]). *Let $f: \mathcal{Z} \rightarrow T$ be a smooth projective morphism to a connected complex manifold, let $0 \in T$, and let $\mathcal{E}$ be a semiregular coherent sheaf on $\mathcal{Z}_0$. Suppose that over a contractible neighbourhood of 0 the flat continuation of every component of $\text{ch}(\mathcal{E})$ is a Hodge class on every fibre. Then $\mathcal{E}$ extends to a coherent sheaf on $f^{-1}(U)$, flat over U , for some open neighbourhood U of 0.*

We return to the split Weil family $\pi: \mathcal{A} \rightarrow S$ of Section 4.4, with its global section ξ of Weil planes and the sets $\Sigma_d \subseteq \Sigma \subseteq S$ of Definition 4.5.

Proposition 5.3. *Let $s_0 \in S$ and let $\mathcal{E}$ be a semiregular coherent sheaf on $A = \mathcal{A}_{s_0}$ such that $\text{ch}_k(\mathcal{E}) \in \mathbb{Q}\eta^k$ for $k \neq n$ and $\text{ch}_n(\mathcal{E}) = a\eta^n + w$ with $a \in \mathbb{Q}$ and $0 \neq w \in W(A)$. Then $\Sigma = S$: the Weil classes are algebraic on every member of the family.*

Proof. The powers of η extend to flat sections that are Hodge classes on every member, and so does w , since the Weil planes form a trivial local system of Hodge classes on S (Section 4.4). So the hypothesis of Theorem 5.2 holds, and $\mathcal{E}$ extends to a sheaf on $\pi^{-1}(U)$, flat over U , for a contractible open neighbourhood U of s_0 in S^{an} . For $t \in U$ its restriction $\mathcal{E}_t$ is algebraic by GAGA and has a finite locally free resolution, so $\text{ch}(\mathcal{E}_t)$ is algebraic, and it is the flat continuation of $\text{ch}(\mathcal{E})$. Hence $w_t = \text{ch}_n(\mathcal{E}_t) - a\eta_t^n$ is a nonzero algebraic class in $W(\mathcal{A}_t)$, and $t \in \Sigma$. Thus $U \subseteq \Sigma = \bigcup_d \Sigma_d$. By the Baire category theorem some Σ_d contains a nonempty open subset of S^{an} ; it is Zariski closed by Lemma 4.6 and S is irreducible, so $\Sigma_d = S$. $\square$

5.4. Schoen’s subvariety. From now on $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$, and $\zeta \in \mathcal{O}_K$ is a primitive cube root of unity. Let X be a curve of genus $g = n + 1 \geq 3$, let $L \in \text{Pic}^0(X)$ have exact order three, and let $\pi: C \rightarrow X$ be the étale cyclic triple cover defined by L , with covering automorphism σ ; thus $\pi_*\mathcal{O}_C = \mathcal{O}_X \oplus L \oplus L^2$, and C has genus $3g - 2$. In $J = J(C)$ put $N = 1 + \sigma + \sigma^2$ and $P = 3 - N$, and let $B = P(J)$, the Prym variety of the cover, with the polarization η induced by the principal polarization of J . Since $N^2 = 3N$, we have $NP = 0$ and $P^2 = 3P$; so P is multiplication by 3 on B , and σ acts on B with $\sigma^2 + \sigma + 1 = 0$, which lets ζ act as σ .

Lemma 5.4. (a) *B is an abelian variety of Weil type for K of dimension $2n$.*

(b) *The hermitian form of η is split.*

(c) *For very general (X, L) , B has maximal Hodge group.*

Proof. (a) By the decomposition of $\pi_*\mathcal{O}_C$, the space $H^0(C, K_C)$ is the sum of $H^0(X, K_X \otimes L^j)$, $j = 0, 1, 2$, on which σ^* acts by the three cube roots of unity. By Riemann–Roch these spaces have dimensions g , $g - 1$ and $g - 1$, since L^j is a nontrivial bundle of degree zero for $j = 1, 2$. Let $P': J \rightarrow B$ be P with its target restricted and $\iota: B \rightarrow J$ the inclusion. Since $P'\iota = 3$ and $P = \iota P'$, pull-back by P' identifies $H^{1,0}(B)$ with the image of $P^* = 3 - N^*$ on $H^{1,0}(J)$, which is the sum of the two nontrivial eigenspaces. So $\dim B = 2(g - 1) = 2n$, and both embeddings of K occur with multiplicity n .

(b) The Riemann form of η is the intersection form E on $H_1(B, \mathbb{Q}) = PH_1(C, \mathbb{Q})$, and a K -subspace is isotropic for the hermitian form exactly when it is isotropic for E . The cover corresponds to a surjection $\phi: H_1(X, \mathbb{Z}) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/3$. Since $\text{Sp}_{2g}(\mathbb{Z})$ maps onto $\text{Sp}_{2g}(\mathbb{Z}/3)$, which is transitive on nonzero vectors, there is a symplectic basis $a_1, b_1, \dots, a_g, b_g$ with $\phi(x) = \langle x, b_1 \rangle \bmod 3$; represent it by simple closed curves in standard position. For $i \geq 2$ the curves a_i and b_i have trivial monodromy, so each lifts to three disjoint closed curves, permuted by σ . Choose lifts $\tilde{a}_i$ and $\tilde{b}_i$ that meet. Then $E(\sigma^k \tilde{a}_i, \sigma^l \tilde{a}_j) = 0$ and $E(\sigma^k \tilde{a}_i, \sigma^l \tilde{b}_j) = \delta_{ij} \delta_{kl}$ for $i, j \geq 2$. The first relation shows that the $\mathbb{Z}[\sigma]$ -span of the classes $P\tilde{a}_i$, $2 \leq i \leq g$, is isotropic. These classes are K -linearly independent: if $\sum_i \alpha_i P\tilde{a}_i = 0$ with $\alpha_i = \sum_k c_{ik} \sigma^k \in \mathbb{Z}[\sigma]$, pairing with $\sigma^l \tilde{b}_j$ gives $3c_{jl} - \sum_k c_{jk} = 0$ for every l , so $c_{j0} = c_{j1} = c_{j2}$ and α_j is a multiple of N , which is zero on B . So they span an isotropic subspace of dimension $n = g - 1$.

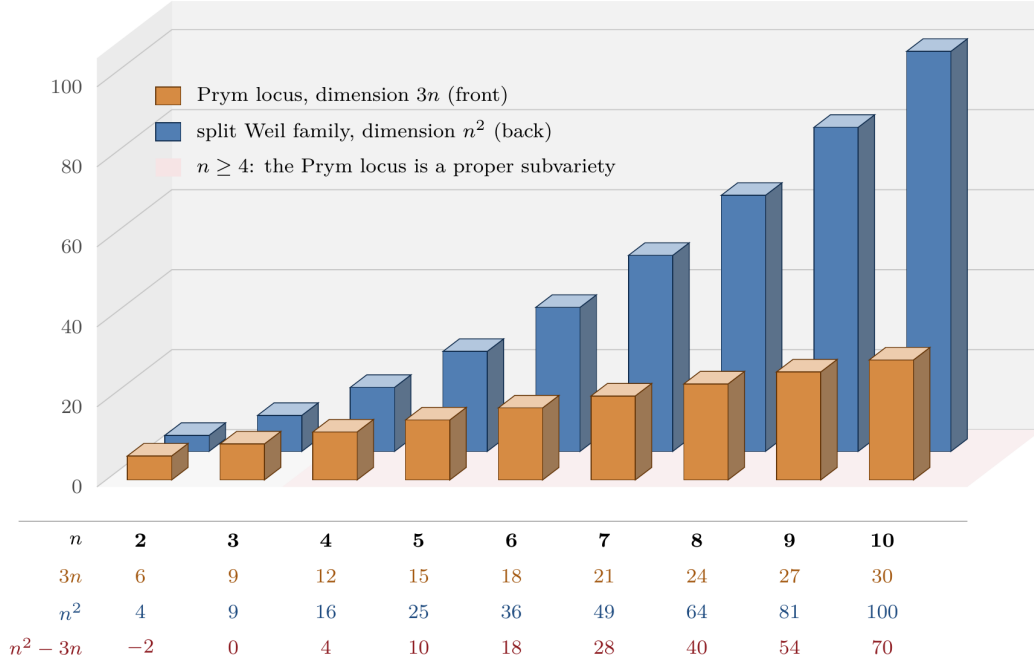


FIGURE 4. The dimension $3n$ of the locus of Prym varieties of étale cyclic triple covers of curves of genus $n + 1$, against the dimension n^2 of the split Weil family of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ in dimension $2n$. For $n \geq 4$ the Prym locus is a proper subvariety, and a semiregular Y would have to deform in the $n^2 - 3n$ remaining directions.

(c) The monodromy of the Prym varieties over the moduli of pairs (X, L) is an arithmetic subgroup of the unitary group [Loo97], so by Borel density its Zariski closure contains $\mathrm{SU}(V, H)$. By André's theorem [And92] the connected monodromy group is contained in the Hodge group of a very general member. Together with $\mathrm{Hg}(B) \subseteq \mathrm{SU}(V, H)$ this gives equality. $\square$

The pairs (X, L) of genus g have $3g - 3 = 3n$ moduli, while the split Weil family of K in dimension $2n$ has dimension n^2 . For $n \leq 3$ Schoen uses these Prym varieties to reach every member [Sch88, Sch98]. For $n \geq 4$ they form a proper subvariety (Figure 4).

The construction. Let $h = 2g - 2 = 2n$. The group $G = (\mathbb{Z}/3)^h \rtimes S_h$ acts on C^h by $(v, \tau) \cdot (c_i)_i = (\sigma^{v_i} c_{\tau^{-1}(i)})_i$, and the quotient is the symmetric product $X^{(h)}$; write $\mu: C^h \rightarrow X^{(h)}$. The map $\varepsilon(v, \tau) = \sum_i v_i$ is a homomorphism $G \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}/3$, with kernel G' . Following Schoen [Sch88, §2], put

$$W_0 = C^h / G', \quad \rho: C^h \rightarrow W_0, \quad \nu: W_0 \rightarrow X^{(h)},$$

and let $\delta = \sigma \times 1 \times \cdots \times 1$, so that $\varepsilon(\delta) = 1$ and δ induces an automorphism $\bar{\delta}$ of W_0 over $X^{(h)}$.

Lemma 5.5. (a) *No element of $G \setminus G'$ has a fixed point on C^h . Hence ν is a connected étale Galois cover with group $\mathbb{Z}/3$, generated by $\bar{\delta}$.*

(b) *G acts freely on $\mu^{-1}(D)$ for every reduced divisor $D \in X^{(h)}$.*

(c) *μ is finite and flat, so μ^{-1} of a subvariety of pure dimension r has pure dimension r .*

Proof. Suppose (v, τ) fixes (c_i) , so that $c_{\tau(i)} = \sigma^{v_{\tau(i)}} c_i$ for all i . Going once around a cycle $(i_1, \dots, i_k)$ of τ gives $c_{i_1} = \sigma^{v_{i_1} + \cdots + v_{i_k}} c_{i_1}$; since σ has no fixed points, the sum of the v_i over every cycle is 0 in $\mathbb{Z}/3$, and so is $\varepsilon(v, \tau)$. This is (a): W_0 is connected as a quotient of C^h ,

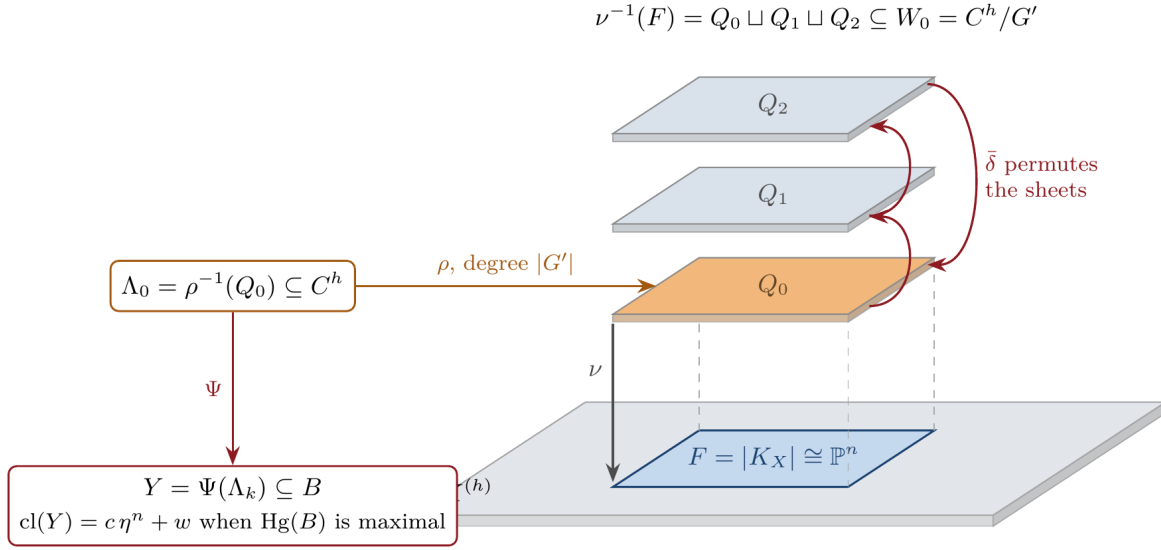


FIGURE 5. Schoen's construction. Over the canonical system $F = |K_X|$ of X , the étale triple cover $\nu: W_0 \rightarrow X^{(h)}$ splits into three sheets, which $\bar{\delta}$ permutes cyclically. $\Lambda_0 \subseteq C^h$ is the preimage of one sheet, and Y is the image under Ψ of one of its components (Theorem E).

and $G/G' \cong \mathbb{Z}/3$ acts freely on it with quotient $X^{(h)}$. If moreover the points $\pi(c_i)$ are distinct, then $\pi(c_{\tau(i)}) = \pi(c_i)$ forces $\tau = 1$, and then $v = 0$; this is (b). The map $C^h \rightarrow X^h$ is étale and $X^h \rightarrow X^{(h)}$ is a finite map between smooth varieties of the same dimension, hence flat. By going down for flat maps, every component of the preimage of a subvariety Z dominates a component of Z , and the fibres are finite; this gives (c). $\square$

Let $u: X^{(h)} \rightarrow \text{Pic}^h(X)$ send D to $\mathcal{O}_X(D)$. Its fibre over $[K_X]$ is the canonical system $F = |K_X| \cong \mathbb{P}^n$. Since F is simply connected, the restriction of ν to $\nu^{-1}(F)$ is a trivial cover: $\nu^{-1}(F) = Q_0 \sqcup Q_1 \sqcup Q_2$ with each Q_t mapped isomorphically onto F , and $\bar{\delta}$, which has no fixed points, permutes the Q_t cyclically; number them so that $\bar{\delta}(Q_t) = Q_{t+1}$. These are the three components of Schoen's construction.¹⁶ Put

$$\Lambda_0 = \rho^{-1}(Q_0) \subseteq C^h,$$

with its reduced structure. It has pure dimension n by Lemma 5.5(c), and since the general member of $|K_X|$ is reduced, ρ is étale over a dense open subset of Q_0 by Lemma 5.5(b), so that $\rho_*[\Lambda_0] = |G'|[Q_0]$. The construction is drawn in Figure 5.

Fix $c_0 \in C$ and let

$$\Psi: C^h \rightarrow B, \quad (c_1, \dots, c_h) \mapsto P\left(\sum_i (c_i - c_0)\right).$$

The key input is a computation of cohomology with twisted coefficients.

Lemma 5.6. *Let $\mathcal{L}$ be a nontrivial local system of rank one on $X^{(h)}$. Then restriction $H^h(X^{(h)}, \mathcal{L}) \rightarrow H^h(F, \mathcal{L})$ is an isomorphism, and $H^h(F, \mathcal{L}) \cong H^{2n}(\mathbb{P}^n, \mathbb{C}) \cong \mathbb{C}$.*

¹⁶Patel and Zhang obtain the same three components by base change of the Abel–Jacobi map along an isogeny onto $J(X)$ [PZ27].

Proof. The fibres of u are projective spaces, so $\mathcal{L}$ is trivial on each of them, and $\mathcal{M} = u_*\mathcal{L}$ is a local system of rank one on $T = \text{Pic}^h(X)$ with $\mathcal{L} = u^*\mathcal{M}$.¹⁷ It is nontrivial, because $\mathcal{L}$ is. As a real manifold T is a torus $(S^1)^{2g}$, and $\mathcal{M}$ is an exterior product of local systems on the circles, at least one of them nontrivial; a nontrivial local system of rank one on a circle has no cohomology, so $H^*(T, \mathcal{M}) = 0$ by the Künneth formula. Let $U = T \setminus \{[K_X]\}$. The exact sequence

$$\cdots \rightarrow H_c^k(U, \mathcal{M}) \rightarrow H^k(T, \mathcal{M}) \rightarrow H^k(\{[K_X]\}, \mathcal{M}) \rightarrow H_c^{k+1}(U, \mathcal{M}) \rightarrow \cdots$$

gives $H_c^1(U, \mathcal{M}) \cong \mathbb{C}$ and $H_c^k(U, \mathcal{M}) = 0$ for $k \neq 1$. For $M \in U$ Riemann–Roch gives $h^0(M) = g - 1 = n$, so over U the map u is the projective bundle of a vector bundle of rank n [ACGH85, Chapter IV], and by the Leray–Hirsch theorem $H_c^*(u^{-1}(U), \mathcal{L}) \cong H_c^*(U, \mathcal{M}) \otimes H^*(\mathbb{P}^{n-1})$, which vanishes outside the degrees $1, 3, \dots, 2n - 1$. The exact sequence of the pair $(X^{(h)}, F)$,

$$H_c^h(u^{-1}(U), \mathcal{L}) \rightarrow H^h(X^{(h)}, \mathcal{L}) \rightarrow H^h(F, \mathcal{L}) \rightarrow H_c^{h+1}(u^{-1}(U), \mathcal{L}),$$

has zero outer terms, since $h = 2n$. Finally $\mathcal{L}$ is trivial on the simply connected $F \cong \mathbb{P}^n$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem E. Write $V_\chi, V_{\bar{\chi}} \subseteq H^1(B, \mathbb{C})$ for the eigenspaces of σ^* with eigenvalues $\lambda = \chi(\zeta)$ and $\bar{\lambda}$, and choose a basis $\bar{y}_1, \dots, \bar{y}_h$ of $V_{\bar{\chi}}$; put $\bar{\omega} = \bar{y}_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge \bar{y}_h$, which spans $\bigwedge^{2n} V_{\bar{\chi}} \subseteq W(B) \otimes \mathbb{C}$.

Step 1: the pull-back of $\bar{\omega}$. Write $\Psi = P' \circ \Xi$, where $\Xi(c_1, \dots, c_h) = \sum_i \text{aj}(c_i)$ and $\text{aj}(c) = [c - c_0]$ is the Abel–Jacobi map. On H^1 the pull-back by the addition map $J^h \rightarrow J$ is the sum of the pull-backs by the projections, so $\Psi^*\bar{y}_j = \sum_i p_i^* \tilde{y}_j$, where p_i is the i -th projection of C^h and $\tilde{y}_j = \text{aj}^* P'^* \bar{y}_j \in H^1(C, \mathbb{C})$. Since P'^* is injective and aj^* is an isomorphism, both commuting with σ^* , the $\tilde{y}_j$ are independent and lie in the $\bar{\lambda}$ -eigenspace of σ^* on $H^1(C, \mathbb{C})$. That eigenspace has dimension h , because the invariant part of $H^1(C, \mathbb{C})$ is $\pi^* H^1(X, \mathbb{C})$, of dimension $2g$, and the two other eigenspaces are conjugate; so the $\tilde{y}_j$ form a basis of it. Now

$$u := \Psi^* \bar{\omega} = \prod_{j=1}^h \left(\sum_{i=1}^h p_i^* \tilde{y}_j \right).$$

A product $\tilde{y}_j \cup \tilde{y}_k$ lies in the $\bar{\lambda}^2$ -eigenspace of $H^2(C, \mathbb{C})$, which is zero because σ acts trivially on $H^2(C)$ and $\bar{\lambda}^2 \neq 1$. So in the expansion only the terms with one factor on each p_i survive: $u = \sum_{s \in S_h} \pm \prod_i p_i^* \tilde{y}_{s(i)}$. By the Künneth formula these terms are linearly independent, and $u \neq 0$. Each term is multiplied by $\bar{\lambda}^{\sum v_i}$ under $(\sigma^{v_1} \times \cdots \times \sigma^{v_h})^*$, and u is symmetric because Ψ is; so u is invariant under G' , and $\delta^* u = \bar{\lambda} u$.

Step 2: restriction to Q_0 . By transfer, ρ^* identifies $H^*(W_0, \mathbb{C})$ with $H^*(C^h, \mathbb{C})^{G'}$, so $u = \rho^* \bar{u}$ for a class $\bar{u} \neq 0$ with $\bar{\delta}^* \bar{u} = \bar{\lambda} \bar{u}$. The decomposition $\nu_* \mathbb{C} = \bigoplus_\psi \mathcal{L}_\psi$ into eigensheaves of $\bar{\delta}$, indexed by the characters ψ of $\mathbb{Z}/3$, identifies the $\psi(1)$ -eigenspace of $\bar{\delta}^*$ on $H^*(W_0, \mathbb{C})$ with $H^*(X^{(h)}, \mathcal{L}_\psi)$, compatibly with restriction to $\nu^{-1}(F)$ and F . For $\psi \neq 1$ the local system $\mathcal{L}_\psi$ is nontrivial, since $H^0(W_0, \mathbb{C})$ is the invariant line. By Lemma 5.6, $\bar{u}$ restricts to a nonzero class on $\nu^{-1}(F) = Q_0 \sqcup Q_1 \sqcup Q_2$. As $\bar{\delta}$ maps Q_0 isomorphically onto Q_t and $\bar{u}$ is an eigenvector,

¹⁷By proper base change the stalk of $u_*\mathcal{L}$ at y is $H^0(u^{-1}(y), \mathcal{L}) \cong \mathbb{C}$, so a nonzero section over the fibre extends over $u^{-1}(D)$ for a small ball $D \ni y$. This set is connected, since u is proper with connected fibres, and a section of a local system of rank one over a connected set is determined by its value at one point and vanishes nowhere unless it is zero. So restriction from $u^{-1}(D)$ to each fibre over D is an isomorphism, $u_*\mathcal{L}$ is locally constant, and $u^*u_*\mathcal{L} \rightarrow \mathcal{L}$ is an isomorphism on stalks.

$\bar{u}|_{Q_0} = 0$ would force $\bar{u}|_{Q_t} = 0$ for every t . Hence $\int_{Q_0} \bar{u} \neq 0$, and

$$\int_B \Psi_*[\Lambda_0] \cup \bar{\omega} = \int_{[\Lambda_0]} \rho^* \bar{u} = |G'| \int_{Q_0} \bar{u} \neq 0.$$

Step 3: one component. The class $\Psi_*[\Lambda_0]$ is $\sum_k e_k \text{cl}(\Psi(\Lambda_k))$, the sum over the irreducible components Λ_k of Λ_0 on which Ψ is generically finite, with e_k the degree of $\Lambda_k \rightarrow \Psi(\Lambda_k)$. By Step 2 one of them, say $Y = \Psi(\Lambda_k)$, satisfies $\int_B \text{cl}(Y) \cup \bar{\omega} \neq 0$. It is irreducible of dimension n . Since $W(B) \otimes \mathbb{C}$ is spanned by $\bar{\omega}$ and its conjugate, $\text{cl}(Y)$ pairs nontrivially with $W(B)$.

Step 4: the shape of the class. If $\text{Hg}(B) = \text{SU}(V, H)$, then Proposition 5.1 gives $\text{cl}(Y) = c\eta^n + w$ with $c \in \mathbb{Q}$ and $w \in W(B)$. Since $\eta^n \cup \bar{\omega} = 0$, Step 3 gives $w \neq 0$. Since $\eta^n \cup w = 0$,

$$c \int_B \eta^{2n} = \int_B \text{cl}(Y) \cup \eta^n = \deg_\eta Y > 0,$$

so $c > 0$. The last assertion of Theorem E is Corollary 5.8 below. $\square$

Corollary 5.7 (Schoen [Sch88]). *For every étale cyclic triple cover of a curve of genus at least three, the Prym variety B is Weil-algebraic.*

Proof. If B has maximal Hodge group, $w = \text{cl}(Y) - c\eta^n$ is a nonzero algebraic class in $W(B)$, and B is Weil-algebraic. By Lemma 5.4(c) this covers every (X, L) outside a countable union of proper closed subsets Z_i of a smooth connected base T over which, after a finite étale base change, the Prym varieties form a polarized abelian scheme with a trivial local system of Weil planes.¹⁸ The proof of Lemma 4.6 shows that the locus where the Weil classes have algebraic representatives of degree at most d is Zariski closed in T . These countably many closed sets, together with the Z_i , cover T , so by the Baire category theorem one of them has interior. It is not a Z_i , so it is one of the degree- d loci, and it equals T . $\square$

Corollary 5.8. *Suppose that for one (X, L) of genus $n + 1 \geq 3$ with maximal Hodge group the subvariety Y of Theorem E is semiregular. Then every abelian variety of split Weil type for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ of dimension $2n$ is Weil-algebraic.*

Proof. The sheaf $\mathcal{O}_Y$ has $\text{ch}_k(\mathcal{O}_Y) = 0$ for $k < n$ and $\text{ch}_n(\mathcal{O}_Y) = \text{cl}(Y) = c\eta^n + w$ with $w \neq 0$ [Ful98, Chapter 15]; for $k > n$ the class $\text{ch}_k(\mathcal{O}_Y)$ is algebraic, hence a multiple of η^k by Proposition 5.1. By Lemma 5.4(b), B is a member of a split Weil family S as in Section 4.4, and Proposition 5.3 gives $\Sigma = S$. Every abelian variety of split Weil type for K of dimension $2n$ is K -isogenous to a member of S ,¹⁹ and a K -isogeny f carries Weil planes to Weil planes and algebraic classes to algebraic classes in both directions, through f^* and $(\deg f)^{-1}f_*$. $\square$

5.5. Transfer by correspondences. Schoen's cycles reach a family of dimension $3n$ inside one of dimension n^2 . One way to spread them is to carry the Weil classes to other varieties by correspondences. This gives a theorem, but a count of dimensions shows that it cannot reach the general member by itself.

Lemma 5.9. *Let B , A_1 and A_2 be of Weil type for K , of dimensions $2(m_1 + m_2)$, $2m_1$ and $2m_2$, and let $f: B \rightarrow A_1 \times A_2$ be an isogeny that commutes with $\mathcal{O}_K$.*

¹⁸Take for T a connected component of a finite étale cover of the moduli space of curves of genus g with level-3 structure, on which L is the section given by a fixed nonzero vector of $(\mathbb{Z}/3)^{2g}$. The monodromy acts on the Weil planes through the determinant, which takes values in the roots of unity of $\mathcal{O}_K$, so it becomes trivial on a finite cover.

¹⁹Two split hermitian forms of the same dimension are isometric, being orthogonal sums of hyperbolic planes. An isometry carries the complex structure of the first variety to a point of the symmetric domain of the second form, and the two lattices are commensurable in the same K -vector space.

- (a) f^* carries a plane in $W(A_1) \otimes W(A_2)$ onto $W(B)$; over $\mathbb{C}$ the plane is spanned by $\omega_1 \otimes \omega_2$ and $\bar{\omega}_1 \otimes \bar{\omega}_2$, where ω_i spans $\bigwedge^{2m_i} V_\chi(A_i)$.
- (b) If two of B, A_1, A_2 are Weil-algebraic, so is the third.

Proof. As in the proof of Corollary 5.8, we may take $B = A_1 \times A_2$. Then $V_\chi(B) = V_\chi(A_1) \oplus V_\chi(A_2)$, and the top exterior power of a sum is the tensor product of the top exterior powers; this is (a). If A_1 and A_2 are Weil-algebraic, every class in $W(A_1) \otimes W(A_2)$ is a sum of products $\text{pr}_1^* \alpha_1 \cup \text{pr}_2^* \alpha_2$ of algebraic classes, so B is Weil-algebraic by (a). Suppose that B and A_2 are Weil-algebraic. On A_2 we have $\omega_2 \cup \omega_2 = 0$, since $\bigwedge^{4m_2} V_\chi(A_2) = 0$, while $p = \int \omega_2 \cup \bar{\omega}_2 \neq 0$, since $\bigwedge^{2m_2} V_\chi \otimes \bigwedge^{2m_2} V_{\bar{\chi}}$ is the top exterior power of $H^1(A_2, \mathbb{C})$; and p is real, because classes of even degree commute. Nonzero rational classes $x \in W(B)$ and $\gamma \in W(A_2)$ have the form $x = s\omega_1 \otimes \omega_2 + \bar{s}\bar{\omega}_1 \otimes \bar{\omega}_2$ and $\gamma = t\omega_2 + \bar{t}\bar{\omega}_2$ with $s, t \neq 0$. The class

$$\text{pr}_{1*}(x \cup \text{pr}_2^* \gamma) = p(st\omega_1 + \bar{s}\bar{t}\bar{\omega}_1)$$

is rational, algebraic, nonzero, and lies in $W(A_1)$. $\square$

Lemma 5.10. *Let K be any imaginary quadratic field, E an elliptic curve with complex multiplication by $\mathcal{O}_K$, and $\bar{E}$ the same curve with $\mathcal{O}_K$ acting through complex conjugation. For $k \geq 1$ the variety $E^k \times \bar{E}^k$, with the product polarization, is of split Weil type, and its Weil classes are polynomials in divisor classes.*

Proof. On $H_1(E, \mathbb{Q}) = K$ the polarization is $\text{Tr}_{K/\mathbb{Q}}(f x \bar{y})$ for some $f \in K$ with $\bar{f} = -f$, so its hermitian form is $x \bar{y}$. For $\bar{E}$ the K -structure is conjugated, and the same Riemann form is $\text{Tr}_{K/\mathbb{Q}}(f \cdot (-\bar{x}y))$, with hermitian form $-\bar{x}y$. So the form of $E^k \times \bar{E}^k$ is $\text{diag}(1, \dots, 1, -1, \dots, -1)$, for which the vectors $e_i + e_{k+i}$ span an isotropic subspace of dimension k , and both embeddings of K occur k times on $H^{1,0}$. With coordinates $z_1, \dots, z_{2k}$ on the factors, V_χ is spanned by $dz_1, \dots, dz_k$ and $d\bar{z}_{k+1}, \dots, d\bar{z}_{2k}$, so up to sign $\omega_\chi = \bigwedge_{i=1}^k (dz_i \wedge d\bar{z}_{k+i})$. Each factor is a class of type $(1, 1)$ on $E \times \bar{E} \cong E \times E$, whose Néron–Severi group has rank $4 = h^{1,1}$ because E has complex multiplication; so it is a complex combination of divisor classes, and so are ω_χ and its conjugate. $\square$

Theorem 5.11. *Let A be an abelian variety of Weil type for $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$, of dimension $2m \geq 2$, on which $\mathcal{O}_K$ acts. There are a smooth curve $C \subseteq A$, stable under ζ and with ζ acting freely on it, so that $C \rightarrow X = C/\zeta$ is an étale cyclic triple cover of a curve of some genus $g \geq m + 1$; an abelian variety A' of Weil type of dimension $2(g - 1 - m)$; and an isogeny commuting with $\mathcal{O}_K$ between the Prym variety of $C \rightarrow X$ and $A \times A'$. For every such curve, A is Weil-algebraic if and only if A' is.*

Proof. The curve. The automorphism ζ has finitely many fixed points, the kernel of the isogeny $1 - \zeta$. Let $\mathcal{N}$ be ample on A . The bundle $\mathcal{N}' = \mathcal{N} \otimes \zeta^* \mathcal{N} \otimes \zeta^{2*} \mathcal{N}$ is isomorphic to its pull-back by ζ , so it carries a linearization for the cyclic group generated by ζ ; ²⁰ its cube descends to an ample line bundle $\bar{\mathcal{M}}$ on the normal quotient $q: A \rightarrow A/\zeta$, since the stabilizers, of order dividing three, act trivially on its fibres. For k large, $2m - 1$ general members D_i of $|\bar{\mathcal{M}}^k|$ meet in a smooth irreducible curve X that avoids the images of the fixed points, by Bertini's theorem. Then $C = q^{-1}(X)$ is étale over X , hence smooth, and it is the complete intersection of the ample divisors $q^* D_i$, hence connected. Schoen observes the existence of such curves in [Sch88, §3].

The surjection. By the Lefschetz hyperplane theorem, restriction $H^1(A, \mathbb{Q}) \rightarrow H^1(C, \mathbb{Q})$ is injective, so the homomorphism $\alpha: J(C) \rightarrow A$ induced by the inclusion is surjective; it

²⁰Choose an isomorphism $\phi: \zeta^* \mathcal{N}' \rightarrow \mathcal{N}'$. The composite of ϕ , $\zeta^* \phi$ and $\zeta^{2*} \phi$ is an automorphism of $\mathcal{N}'$, hence a scalar c , and $c^{-1/3} \phi$ is a linearization.

commutes with ζ . Since $1 + \zeta + \zeta^2 = 0$ in $\mathcal{O}_K$, $\alpha N = 0$ and $\alpha P = 3\alpha$. So α maps the Prym variety $B = P(J(C))$ onto A , and $g - 1 \geq m$.

The complement. Let A' be the connected component of the kernel of $\alpha|_B$ and A'' its complement in B for the induced polarization. Both are stable under σ , which preserves the polarization, so $\mathcal{O}_K$ acts on them, and $A'' \rightarrow A$ and $A' \times A'' \rightarrow B$ are isogenies commuting with $\mathcal{O}_K$. By Lemma 5.4(a) both embeddings of K occur $g - 1$ times on $H^{1,0}(B)$, and they occur m times on $H^{1,0}(A)$; so they occur $g - 1 - m$ times on $H^{1,0}(A')$, and A' is of Weil type.

The equivalence. B is Weil-algebraic by Corollary 5.7, and Lemma 5.9(b) gives the equivalence. $\square$

Corollary 5.12. *A is Weil-algebraic as soon as, for one curve as in Theorem 5.11, the complement A' is K -isogenous to a product of Weil-algebraic varieties, such as Prym varieties of étale cyclic triple covers (Corollary 5.7), abelian surfaces of Weil type (Theorem 2.3), and the varieties $E^k \times \bar{E}^k$ (Lemma 5.10).*

Proof. Products of Weil-algebraic varieties are Weil-algebraic by Lemma 5.9(b), and Theorem 5.11 applies. $\square$

When $g - 1 = m$ the complement is zero and A is K -isogenous to a Prym variety. For larger g the theorem trades the Weil classes of A for those of A' , and since curves of higher degree give complements of every size, one might hope to choose the curve so that A' is of a known kind. The count below says that for $m \geq 4$ this hope fails at the general member unless an unexpected intersection occurs.

Remark 5.13. Pryms of étale triple covers of curves of genus $m + k + 1$ form a family of dimension $3(m + k)$ inside the Weil family of dimension $(m + k)^2$. The varieties K -isogenous to $A \times A'$, with A in the family of dimension m^2 and A' in a family of dimension f , form a subvariety of dimension $m^2 + f$. For A to be general the two must meet in dimension at least m^2 , which needs $3(m + k) + f \geq (m + k)^2$ unless they meet in excess dimension. Products of the varieties of Corollary 5.12 of total dimension $2k$ have at most $3k$ moduli, and $3(m + k) + 3k < (m + k)^2$ for every $k \geq 0$ once $m \geq 4$. For $m = 3$ only $k = 0$ passes, the Prym locus itself, and for $m = 2$ exactly $k \leq 2$ pass. So Corollary 5.12 reaches only a meagre part of the family once $m \geq 4$, unless the Prym locus meets these product loci in excess dimension, as Schoen anticipated [Sch88, §3]. This is a count, not a proof that no such intersection exists.

5.6. Where it stops. Everything on the Weil route now rests on one question.

Question 5.14. Let $n \geq 4$ and let (X, L) be very general of genus $n + 1$. Is the subvariety $Y \subseteq B$ of Theorem E semiregular?

A positive answer forces Y to deform with B to first order along all n^2 directions of the Weil family, and not only along the $3n$ directions of the Prym locus; so it asks for $n^2 - 3n$ unexpected first order deformations. We have not been able to decide the question, and the closest analogue points the other way.

The Abel–Jacobi curve $C \subseteq J(C)$ of a curve of genus $g \geq 4$ is built from the same map as Y . Its class $\theta^{g-1}/(g-1)!$ is a Hodge class on every principally polarized abelian variety. Yet by the criterion of Matsusaka and Ran [Mat59, Ran81] a curve with this class exists only on Jacobians and products of Jacobians, which form a proper subvariety of the moduli space $\mathcal{A}_g$. So the curve does not deform in the directions normal to the Jacobian locus, and by Theorem 5.2 it is not semiregular. The number of those directions is classical. The tangent space to $\mathcal{A}_g$ at $J(C)$ is dual to $\text{Sym}^2 H^0(K_C)$, the tangent space to the Jacobian locus is dual to $H^0(2K_C)$, and by Max Noether’s theorem the multiplication map between them is surjective for non-hyperelliptic

C , with kernel the space I_2 of quadrics containing the canonical curve. So the Jacobian locus has codimension

$$\dim I_2 = \binom{g+1}{2} - (3g-3) = \frac{(g-2)(g-3)}{2}$$

at $J(C)$. Schoen's subvariety is the analogue one step up, built from the fibre of the Abel–Jacobi map over the canonical class, and the corresponding codimension, that of the Prym locus in the Weil family, is $n^2 - 3n$. Nothing in the construction of Y moves it off the Prym locus. This is an analogy and not a proof.

Nor can a branched cover take the place of the étale one, because branching does not enlarge the Prym locus enough.

Proposition 5.15. *Let $\pi: C \rightarrow X$ be a cyclic triple cover of a curve of genus q , branched at r points, with covering automorphism σ , and let its Prym variety, the image of $3 - N$ on $J(C)$ with $N = 1 + \sigma + \sigma^2$, have dimension $2n$. Then $2q + r = 2n + 2$, and the covers with these invariants form finitely many families, each of dimension $q + 2n - 1 \leq 3n$, with equality only for étale covers of curves of genus $n + 1$. In particular, for $n \geq 4$ a very general member of the split Weil family of K in dimension $2n$ is not K -isogenous to the Prym variety of any cyclic triple cover, étale or branched.*

Proof. Since 3 is prime, every branch point is totally ramified, and the Riemann–Hurwitz formula $2g(C) - 2 = 3(2q - 2) + 2r$ gives $g(C) = 3q - 2 + r$. The invariant part of $H^0(C, K_C)$ under σ^* is $\pi^* H^0(X, K_X)$, of dimension q , and as in the proof of Lemma 5.4(a) the space $H^{1,0}$ of the Prym variety is the sum of the two other eigenspaces. So the Prym variety has dimension $g(C) - q = 2q - 2 + r$, and $2q + r = 2n + 2$. Given X and the r branch points, the cover corresponds to a surjection from the fundamental group of the punctured curve onto $\mathbb{Z}/3$, and there are finitely many of these. So the covers form finitely many families, of dimension $3q - 3 + r$ when $q \geq 2$, r when $q = 1$, and $r - 3$ when $q = 0$; by $r = 2n + 2 - 2q$ each of these equals $q + 2n - 1$. As $r \geq 0$, $q \leq n + 1$, so the dimension is at most $3n$, and it equals $3n$ exactly when $q = n + 1$ and $r = 0$.

The Prym varieties of each family form the image of a variety of dimension at most $3n$ in the moduli space, and the K -isogenies of a given degree carry it to finitely many subvarieties of at most the same dimension. The members of the split Weil family that are K -isogenous to such a Prym variety therefore lie in a countable union of subvarieties of dimension at most $3n$, which for $n \geq 4$ is less than n^2 . $\square$

A weaker hypothesis would do if the semiregularity theorem were sharper. Markman asks whether Theorem 5.2 holds when $\sigma_{\mathcal{E}}$ is injective only on the image of the evaluation map from the second Hochschild cohomology $HH^2(Z)$ to $\text{Ext}^2(\mathcal{E}, \mathcal{E})$ [Mar25b, Question 11.4]. A positive answer would replace the semiregularity of $\mathcal{O}_Y$ in Corollary 5.8 by injectivity of $\sigma_{\mathcal{O}_Y}$ on that image, a condition that involves only the deformations of B and of its category of sheaves. For a general imaginary quadratic field, cycles representing Weil classes at members with maximal Hodge group are known in dimension four, and for split forms in dimension six [Mar25a]. For nonsplit forms in dimension six, and in dimension $2n \geq 8$ for fields other than $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ and $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-1})$, we know of none, so the route has nothing to deform.

6. THE ROUTES

We now treat the statements as propositional letters and the results of the paper as rules between them. Besides the seven statements of Definition 2.7 and (HC) there are three more: (SR), that the subvariety Y of Theorem E is semiregular for some (X, L) of each genus $n + 1 \geq 5$

with maximal Hodge group; (W3), that the Weil classes are algebraic on every abelian variety of split Weil type for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$; and (Fer), the Hodge conjecture for every Fermat variety. The rules are listed in Table 1.

Implication	Source
$(F2) \wedge (F3') \Rightarrow (HC)$	Section 4.3: if (F2) holds then $\text{Ab}^p(X) = \text{Alg}^p(X)$
$(HC) \Rightarrow (F2), (F3'), (L), (M), (V)$	Lemma 2.11
$(L) \wedge (M) \Rightarrow (HC)$	Proposition 2.8, after André [And96]
$(L) \Rightarrow (F2)$	Abdulali, André [Mil20, Theorem 4]
$(V) \Rightarrow (F2)$	[Mil20, Theorem 3 and Remark 2]
$(V) \Rightarrow (IP)$	(IP) is a case of (V)
$(F3') \Rightarrow (M)$	Proposition 2.9
$(CM) \wedge (IP) \Rightarrow (F2)$	Proposition 4.4
$(F2) \Rightarrow (CM), (IP)$	Proposition 4.4
$(CM) \Rightarrow (\text{Fer}), (HC) \Rightarrow (\text{Fer})$	Theorem C
$(SR) \Rightarrow (W3)$	Corollary 5.8 for $2n \geq 8$; Theorem 2.3 and [Sch88, Sch98] for $2n \leq 6$
$(F2) \Rightarrow (W3)$	(W3) is a case of (F2)

TABLE 1. The implications between the statements. A set of statements *implies* a statement if the statement is reached from the set by repeated use of these rules.

For $2n \leq 6$ the conclusion of (SR) is already known, which is why (SR) only concerns the genera $n + 1 \geq 5$. A set of statements is *closed* if it contains the conclusion of every rule whose premises it contains. The statements implied by a set S form the smallest closed set containing S , so a closed set that contains S and not (HC) shows that (HC) does not follow from S .

Lemma 6.1. *Let $\mathcal{U}$ be the set of all eleven statements. The four sets*

$$\begin{aligned} T_1 &= \mathcal{U} \setminus \{(HC), (M), (F3')\}, & T_2 &= \mathcal{U} \setminus \{(HC), (L), (F3')\}, \\ T_3 &= \mathcal{U} \setminus \{(HC), (F2), (L), (V), (IP)\}, & T_4 &= \mathcal{U} \setminus \{(HC), (F2), (L), (V), (CM)\} \end{aligned}$$

are closed, and so is $\{(CM), (\text{Fer})\}$.

Proof. A rule can fail to be respected by a set only if its conclusion is missing from the set while all its premises are present. We check the rules whose conclusions are missing. In T_1 the missing conclusions are (HC), (M) and (F3'); every rule concluding one of them has a premise among (HC), (F3') and (M), which are missing. In T_2 the rules concluding (HC), (L) or (F3') need one of (F3'), (HC) or (L). In T_3 every rule concluding (HC), (F2), (L), (V) or (IP) has a premise among (F2), (HC), (L), (V) and (IP); the rule $(CM) \wedge (IP) \Rightarrow (F2)$ is blocked by (IP). T_4 is the same with (CM) in place of (IP). In $\{(CM), (\text{Fer})\}$ the only rule with all premises present is $(CM) \Rightarrow (\text{Fer})$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem B. Let S be a set of statements, not containing (HC), that implies (HC). Then S is contained in none of $T_1, \dots, T_4$, so it meets each of

$$\{(M), (F3')\}, \quad \{(L), (F3')\}, \quad \{(F2), (L), (V), (IP)\}, \quad \{(F2), (L), (V), (CM)\}.$$

If $(F3') \notin S$, the first two give $(M), (L) \in S$, which is (b). If $(F3') \in S$ and S contains none of $(F2), (L), (V)$, the last two give $(IP), (CM) \in S$. This is (a).

Conversely, $\{(F2), (F3')\}$ and $\{(L), (M)\}$ imply (HC) directly, and $\{(L), (F3')\}$, $\{(V), (F3')\}$ and $\{(CM), (IP), (F3')\}$ imply (F2) and then (HC). From (HC) the rules give $(F2), (F3'), (L), (M), (V)$, then $(CM), (IP), (W3)$ and (Fer): every statement except (SR). No minimal set contains (SR), because (SR) is a premise only of the rule that concludes (W3), and (W3) is a premise of no rule. $\square$

Corollary 6.2. (i) *A set of statements that implies (HC) and contains neither (F2) nor (F3') contains (L) and (M); by Theorem A this pair is equivalent to (HC).*
(ii) *Every set that implies (HC) also implies (F2) and (F3').*
(iii) *A set that implies (HC) still implies it when (SR) is removed.*
(iv) *(CM) implies (Fer) and nothing else; neither $\{(CM), (F3')\}$ nor $\{(CM), (SR)\}$ implies (HC).*

Proof. (i) is Theorem B(b), since (a) requires $(F3')$. (ii) holds because (HC) implies $(F2)$ and $(F3')$. (iii) is the last sentence of the proof of Theorem B. For (iv), $\{(CM), (Fer)\}$ is closed by Lemma 6.1, and $\{(CM), (F3')\}$ and $\{(CM), (SR)\}$ lie in the closed set T_3 , which does not contain (HC). $\square$

So the conjecture can be reached without assuming $(F2)$ or $(F3')$, but only through (L) and (M) , which carry the whole conjecture between them; and it cannot be reached without proving $(F2)$ and $(F3')$ along the way. Schoen's subvariety, if it is semiregular, settles a family of Weil classes in every dimension, but it lies on no route to (HC). The closed set $\{(CM), (Fer)\}$ is a valuation of the eleven statements in which every rule of Table 1 holds, (CM) holds, and (HC) fails: the rules alone cannot derive the conjecture from the preprint [Ope26b].

7. WHAT IS PROVED AND WHAT IS NOT

Proved. The following hold without any unproved hypothesis.

- (1) The equivalences of Theorem A, and the description in Theorem B and Corollary 6.2 of every set of the statements of Table 1 from which the conjecture follows by those implications.
- (2) The statement $(F3')$ for every Fermat variety, every product of Fermat varieties and every variety onto which such a product maps surjectively (Theorem C), together with the description of the Hodge classes of Fermat varieties by characters (Proposition 3.6).
- (3) The closedness of the bounded-degree loci Σ_d in a split Weil family, and the criterion of Theorem D for $\Sigma = S$.
- (4) For every étale cyclic triple cover of a curve of genus $n + 1 \geq 3$: its Prym variety is of split Weil type (Lemma 5.4); Schoen's construction gives an irreducible n -dimensional subvariety Y whose class pairs nontrivially with the Weil plane; at a member with maximal Hodge group $\text{cl}(Y) = c\eta^n + w$ with $c > 0$ and $w \neq 0$ (Theorem E); and the Prym variety is Weil-algebraic (Corollary 5.7, first proved by Schoen).
- (5) The transfer of Theorem 5.11: an abelian variety of Weil type for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ is, up to isogeny, a factor $A \times A'$ of a Prym variety, and A is Weil-algebraic if and only if A' is.
- (6) The count of Proposition 5.15: Prym varieties of cyclic triple covers, étale or branched, form families of dimension at most $3n$, so for $n \geq 4$ they miss the very general member of the split Weil family.

Proved under a stated hypothesis.

- (7) Under (CM): the Hodge conjecture for every Fermat variety, every product of Fermat varieties and every variety such a product dominates (Theorem C), and the algebraicity of the Weil classes at every CM point of a split Weil family (Theorem D).
- (8) Under the semiregularity of one subvariety Y of genus $n + 1$ with maximal Hodge group: the Weil classes of every abelian variety of split Weil type for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ of dimension $2n$ (Corollary 5.8).

Not proved. The Hodge conjecture; each of (F2), (F3'), (L), (M), (V), (IP); the semiregularity of Y for any $n \geq 4$ (Question 5.14); and (CM), which is claimed in the unrefered preprint [Ope26b] and used here only as a hypothesis.

The first open cases. By Theorem B every route passes through (F2) and (F3'), and each has a first case that no known method reaches.

Weil classes in dimensions six and eight. (F2) holds in dimension at most five by [MZ99] and the Weil fourfolds of the preprint [Mar25a] (Section 5.2). In dimension six the Weil classes of split forms are algebraic, for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ by [Sch88, Sch98] and in general by [Mar25a], and those of nonsplit forms are open. For $2n = 8$ we know of no family of Weil type whose general member has maximal Hodge group and which carries algebraic Weil classes at every member. For the split family of $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ this is Question 5.14 with $n = 4$, where Y would have to deform in $n^2 - 3n = 4$ directions beyond the Prym locus. Proposition 5.15 shows that Prym varieties of branched cyclic triple covers do not reach the general member either, and Remark 5.13 shows the same for Corollary 5.12. Preprints announcing the split eightfolds are cited in [BMB26]; we could not locate them in the public release of [Ope26b], and we do not use them.

Beyond Weil classes. On the square $A \times A$ of a Mumford fourfold A [Mum69] there are Hodge classes that are not generated by divisor classes and Weil classes. They are the first instance of (F2) that the Weil route does not cover. In [BMB26, Theorem 21.4] they are reduced to the Kuga–Satake class of one K3 surface, which is not known to be algebraic.

The first case of (F3'). For a K3 surface S whose transcendental lattice has a totally real field of degree at least two as its algebra of Hodge endomorphisms, the classes on $S \times S$ that induce these endomorphisms are not known to be algebraic in general; $S \times S$ lies in the reach of abelian varieties by algebraic correspondences once the Kuga–Satake correspondence of S is algebraic [BMB26, Remark 20.36].

So the conjecture is equivalent to two statements, and each has an explicit first open case. What this paper adds to the Weil case is that, for $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-3})$ in every dimension, it now depends on a single, explicitly constructed subvariety of a Prym variety and the question whether it is semiregular.

A note on preparation. Parts of this paper and of the code that checks its finite steps were drafted with the help of an AI assistant, working under the author's direction. Responsibility for the content rests with the author.

APPENDIX A. MACHINE CHECKS

No proof in this paper depends on a computer. The finite steps have been repeated by machine, in several independent implementations, and the files are in the author's repository <https://github.com/creelie/e84hc> under `verification/`; each release of the repository is archived on Zenodo under the DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23234362. One script, `shell/run_all.sh`, runs them all and compares their outputs.

Exact computations in three languages. The program `closure_checks` exists in Python, Julia and C, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic, and the three versions print the same 207 lines; the shell script compares them line by line and against a stored copy. The lines fall into six groups.

- F Fermat varieties X_m^n for $n = 2$, $m \leq 12$ and for $n = 4$, $m \leq 8$: the characters of Proposition 3.6, the primitive Betti number against $((m-1)^{n+2} + (-1)^n(m-1))/m$, the middle Hodge number, the Hodge characters and those of pair type; for surfaces, $h^{1,1} = (2m^3 - 6m^2 + 7m)/3$, the Picard number ρ , and Aoki and Shioda's formula $\rho = 3(m-1)(m-2) + 1$ for $(m, 6) = 1$ [AS83]. The values $\rho = 20, 37, 86$ for $m = 4, 5, 6$ appear among them.
- J Fermat curves of degree $m \leq 30$: every orbit of characters under $(\mathbb{Z}/m)^\times$ has an odd type function, as in the proof of Lemma 3.3.
- S The switch lemma (Lemma 4.1) for all pairs of lists with $p \leq 4$ rows and $s \leq 3$ columns: the column correction reaches the target by two-row switches, each preserving the column sums, in at most $s\lfloor p/2 \rfloor$ steps.
- G The signs $(-1)^{p(p-1)/2}$ of the permutations that regroup a product of $2p$ classes of degree one between interleaved and blocked order, for $p \leq 10$.
- W The dimensions $3n$ and n^2 of the Prym locus and the Weil family, and the count of Remark 5.13: the pairs (m, k) with $3(m+k) + 3k \geq (m+k)^2$, which are $k \leq 2$ for $m = 2$, $k = 0$ for $m = 3$, and none for $4 \leq m < 60$, $k < 200$; and the count of Proposition 5.15: for $2 \leq n \leq 12$ and every genus q , the Riemann–Hurwitz relation, the dimension $q + 2n - 1$ of the family, and its unique maximum $3n$ at $q = n + 1$, $r = 0$.
- L The rules of Table 1: the closed sets of Lemma 6.1; the valuation in which (CM) holds and (HC) fails; the five minimal sets of Theorem B, found by enumerating all sets of statements; and the fact that (L) and (M) form the only minimal set avoiding (F2), (F3'), (IP), (CM) and (SR).

Lean. The file `lean/Closure.lean` is checked by the kernel of Lean 4 with the core library only, without `sorry` and without `native_decide`; every theorem in it depends only on the standard axioms. It states the rules of Table 1 as an inductive derivability relation and proves: that the four sets of Lemma 6.1 and the set $\{(CM), (Fer)\}$ are closed; Theorem B itself, for an arbitrary set of statements; Corollary 6.2(i); and the derivations of (HC) from each of the five minimal sets. It also proves, for all sizes at once, the counting identity behind the switch lemma, the equivalence $3n < n^2 \iff n \geq 4$, the inequality of Remark 5.13 for every $m \geq 4$ and $k \geq 0$, and the count of Proposition 5.15 for all n , q and r ; and it computes the Picard numbers 20, 37 and 86 of the Fermat quartic, quintic and sextic surfaces from the characters, by evaluation in the kernel.

Macaulay2. Two scripts use Macaulay2. The first computes the primitive Hodge numbers of the Fermat surfaces and fourfolds from the Jacobian ring, $h_{\text{prim}}^{n-q,q} = \dim R_{(q+1)m-(n+2)}$ with $R = \mathbb{Q}[x_0, \dots, x_{n+1}]/(x_0^{m-1}, \dots, x_{n+1}^{m-1})$ [Gri69], and checks that they agree with the character counts of item F. The second takes random smooth plane curves of degree $4 \leq d \leq 8$ modulo the prime 32003 and checks Max Noether's theorem in the form used in Section 5.6: the multiplication map $\text{Sym}^2 H^0(K) \rightarrow H^0(2K)$ has rank $3g - 3$, so $\dim I_2 = (g-2)(g-3)/2$. A smooth curve of full rank modulo p is smooth and of full rank over $\mathbb{Q}$, so these are checks over $\mathbb{Q}$.

References. The script `references/check_references.py` looks up every entry of the bibliography online, through its DOI where it has one and through Crossref, DataCite, arXiv or

the publisher's page otherwise, and compares title, year, volume and pages; its report is stored next to it.

None of these checks touches the geometry the paper relies on, and none of them bears on Question 5.14.

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